Leader's Guide

For small groups, church retreats, couples, and pastors and leaders

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How to use this guide

This guide is for anyone who leads The Christian Spiritual Reset with other people: a small group, a church retreat, a couples' retreat or a group of pastors. It is built on the book's Program 6, The Small-Group and Church Retreat, as the course design asks, and it carries Program 5's notes for couples and Program 7's notes for pastors and leaders.

For each of the 26 units you will find the aim of the meeting, background for leaders, notes on any Greek or Hebrew word, a plan for the meeting, the book's cautions, and a "Don't miss this" box: the points that must not become confused. The Don't miss this boxes are taken unchanged from the approved scripts. Everything else is for leaders only; group members do not need it.

Choose one format. Decide first whether you are running a group retreat, a couples' retreat or a pastors' retreat, and use the instructions for that format. Do not combine every instruction in this guide into one retreat: the notes for couples and for pastors are additions to the sessions for those formats only.

The course is written for adults. Retreats involving minors require age-appropriate material, parental arrangements, trained safeguarding personnel and the church's youth-protection procedures. Do not adapt this course for young people without that framework.

What the leader is, and is not

The leader is a facilitator: someone who holds the schedule, reads the passages, times the silences, and keeps the group safe. The leader is not a counsellor, not a therapist, and not the person to whom everyone's confessions and griefs are addressed. Say this at the first meeting, and mean it.

The most important thing you will do is protect people from being pushed further than they can safely go, including by you.

A word to pastors leading this. You may be more tired than anyone in the room. Do not lead this retreat as a substitute for taking it. The notes for pastors and leaders below are for you.

How the course is shaped

Part	Units	What happens
Part 1 · Understand	Lessons 1–5	Why we are tired, why rest is not running away, how Jesus withdrew, what is happening to us, and what a retreat can and cannot do.
Part 2 · Prepare	Lessons 6–11	Length and place, intention, preparing the heart, the digital boundary, food and rest, and the fear of silence. Lesson 11 ends with Before My Retreat.
Part 3 · The Retreat	Sessions 1–10	The retreat itself. Sessions 1, 2, 3, 7 and 10 are the core; Sessions 4 and 5 are in the fuller plans; Sessions 6, 8 and 9 are optional.
Part 4 · Come Home Well	Lessons 12–16	The first month home: testing, action, a rule of life, when to seek more help, and Day 30. The page Your First 30 Days Home shows the calendar.

Every member watches the teaching privately, on the course pages, before the group meets. Reading or showing every teaching in the group turns the course into a seminar and lengthens every meeting. The group meets for the passage, the questions, the silence and prayer.

A suggested pathway for a group (optional)

The book gives the retreat's group formats (below). For the lessons before and after it, this guide suggests a pathway. **It is optional, and it is not a requirement for completing the retreat.** A church that cannot hold preparation meetings can still run a well-prepared retreat, provided every participant completes the essential preparation beforehand.

Pathway	Before the retreat	The retreat	After the retreat
Minimum	No meetings. Each participant watches all of Lessons 1–11 privately. Before the retreat, each also does the practical preparation of three of them: chooses their path (Lesson 5), writes their intention (Lesson 7) and sets up and tests their phone plan (Lesson 9), and fills in Before My Retreat (Lesson 11).	Any format below.	Each watches Lessons 12–16 privately; one Day 30 meeting if possible.
Recommended	Six meetings, lessons paired: 1–2, 3–4, 5, 6–7, 8–9, 10–11.	A residential weekend, a Friday-to-Sunday weekend or a one-day retreat.	Three meetings: week 1 (Lessons 12 and 13), week 3 (Lesson 14), Day 30 (Lesson 16).
Extended	Eleven weekly meetings, one lesson each.	The weekly small group: one session a week over seven to ten weeks.	The same three meetings, or the 30-day plan together week by week.

The table below shows the recommended pathway in more detail.

When	Meetings	Notes
Before the retreat	Lessons 1–11: one lesson a meeting (eleven weeks), or paired as six	Lesson 5 is best on its own. Lessons 7 and 9 must be done before the retreat: a

	meetings: 1–2, 3–4, 5, 6–7, 8–9, 10–11	group that arrives without an intention or a phone plan spends Day 1 finding one.
The retreat	A residential weekend, a Friday-to-Sunday weekend, a one-day church retreat, or one session a week	See “Running the retreat as a group” below.
The first month home	Week 1: Lessons 12 and 13 · Week 3: Lesson 14 · Day 30: Lesson 16	Lesson 12 is watched privately on the first morning home. Lesson 15 is for whenever it applies: members watch it privately; its questions in a group are general, never personal.

A lesson meeting (about 60 to 75 minutes)

1. **Welcome** (5 minutes). Repeat the rules for sharing in one or two sentences.
2. **Look back** (5 minutes), where the lesson has a look-back card: a learning exercise, never a test.
3. **The passage** (15 minutes). Read it aloud, then use the passage questions in this guide.
4. **The three discussion questions** (25 minutes), from the lesson page. Use the leader’s notes; do not read them out as answers.
5. **The step** (5 minutes). Explain this week’s step. It is done privately; no one is asked to share what they wrote.
6. **Prayer** (5 minutes). The leader prays, or the group prays silently. No one is asked to pray aloud.

Before the retreat: the leader’s preparation

- Read the whole book, including Chapter 5 (Lesson 5), before you lead anything. Take the retreat yourself first if at all possible.
- Know your church’s safeguarding policy and your reporting obligations, and tell the group what they are before any sharing begins. A leader cannot promise absolute confidentiality, and should not.
- Appoint a safeguarding lead who has accepted the role, and arrange an external professional or crisis contact before the retreat. Do not assume that a participant who happens to be professionally qualified will act as the emergency responder.
- Know the local crisis and emergency numbers. Have a quiet room available where someone can go with a companion if a session overwhelms them.
- Make sure members have done Part 2, and especially Lessons 7 and 9 (the intention and the phone plan), before they come.
- Ask members to watch each session’s teaching privately before the group gathers for it.
- Decide in advance what will be shared and what will not, and tell the group. The default is that almost nothing from the sessions is shared aloud.
- At the first gathering, agree how members want to be checked on if they leave a session: a quiet message, a designated companion, or being given space unless there is a safety concern.

Group size: six to twelve is workable. For more than twelve, break into groups of six to eight for any sharing, with a facilitator in each. Do not run sharing in a larger group: people will either stay silent or say too much.

The rules for sharing

State these at the first gathering, and repeat them before each sharing time.

1. Sharing is always optional. “Pass” is a complete contribution, and no one will be asked why.
2. Share what you noticed, not what you concluded, and never what someone else in the room wrote or said.
3. No advice, no fixing, no interpreting another person’s experience. The response to a share is “thank you,” or silence.

4. Everyone agrees not to repeat another person's story outside the group. This is a serious commitment, subject to the safeguarding limits already stated, though no group can guarantee absolute confidentiality.
5. Anyone may leave any session, any silence, or any sharing, without explanation, and will be checked on in the way agreed at the start.

Running the retreat as a group

The shape of each session in a group

Members watch the teaching privately beforehand. The group gathers for the passage, a brief introduction from the leader, the guided prayer and the silence. Members then go to separate places for the self-assessment, journaling and exercise. The group regathers only for optional sharing where the timetable includes it.

Session 5 is different. The leader introduces the passage, then gives members complete privacy for the prayer, journaling and exercise. No personal confession is spoken to the group or the facilitator.

The residential weekend (the book's timetable)

Sessions 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 7 and 10. Times assume an evening arrival and are adjustable.

When	Together	Apart	Notes
Friday evening	Welcome, rules for sharing, safeguarding statement, check-in method, the psalm from Lesson 8, sleep		No session.
Saturday morning	Session 1: passage, introduction, prayer, silence (30 min)	Journaling and exercise (45 min)	Optional sharing after lunch, not before.
Saturday midday	Lunch, rest		
Saturday afternoon	Session 2: passage, prayer, silence (30 min)	Journaling; noticing exercise outdoors (60 min)	Optional sharing (30 min max) on Sessions 1 and 2. Free evening.
Sunday morning	Session 3: passage, prayer, silence (30 min)	Journaling and cards (60 min)	Optional sharing (30 min max). Long break before lunch.
Sunday midday	Lunch, long rest		Two hours.
Sunday afternoon	Session 4: passage, prayer, short silence (25 min)	Journaling and lament (60 min)	No sharing. Long break. Quiet room staffed.
Sunday evening	Free		Session 5 is not done on Sunday evening in a group.
Monday morning	Session 5: passage and introduction only (15 min)	Prayer, journaling, exercise in complete privacy (60 min)	No sharing. Break.
Monday late morning	Session 7: passage, prayer, silence (35 min)	Journaling and Scripture exercise (60 min)	Optional sharing (30 min max) after lunch.
Monday afternoon	Lunch, rest; Session 10 passage and prayer together first (20 min)	Session 10 journaling and four cards (60 min)	
Monday late afternoon	Closing: each may share one card, optionally; the leader reads the blessing over the group		Then departure, with the travel cautions from Session 10.

The Friday-to-Sunday weekend (an adapted route)

The book allows a shorter weekend: drop Sessions 5 and 7, and do Session 10 on Sunday afternoon. This is a deliberately adapted retreat, not the full residential plan. Tell participants at the start which sessions they will complete afterwards, on their own:

- **Session 7** (Listening for God's Direction) is a core session. Participants complete it at home in the first week back, ideally within a day or two, because Lesson 12 tests the "What I sense" card that Session 7 produces. Their plan is recorded on the course page as complete only once Session 7 is done.
- **Session 5** (Confession and Grace) is taken at home when they are rested and settled, in the 30-day plan. It is not required for the record, and it is never done in a hurry.

The one-day church retreat

Sessions 1, 2, 3, 7 and 10, following the One-Day Retreat plan: passages and silences together, journaling and exercises apart, brief optional sharing after Sessions 2 and 3, and a closing with the blessing. Session 7 may be dropped if people need more rest; a one-day retreat of four sessions is still a retreat.

The weekly small group

One session per meeting, over seven to ten weeks. The leader reads the passage and leads a shortened silence together; the teaching, journaling and exercise are done at home before the next meeting. Open each meeting with brief optional sharing about the previous session's exercise.

- Take a week off between Sessions 4 and 5, and between Sessions 5 and 6 if you include Session 6.
- Do not include Session 6 unless the group is small and well established, and the leader has considered Session 6's conditions carefully.
- The 30-day plan (Lessons 12 to 16) can be done together as the final weeks.

Care and safety in the group

When someone is in trouble

If a member becomes distressed, the safeguarding lead or a designated leader goes with them to the quiet room, sits with them, uses the orientation exercise from Lesson 5 if needed, and does not try to counsel them. If the distress is severe, involves safety, or does not settle, the leader contacts the arranged professional or emergency services, and does not leave the person alone.

Afterwards, the leader follows up within a day and helps them find ongoing support, seeking the person's agreement wherever possible. If there is immediate danger or a safeguarding obligation, follow the agreed emergency and reporting procedure even when consent cannot first be obtained. None of this is announced to the group.

Throughout the course

- Every lesson page carries a short safety note, and Lesson 15 puts its safety card at the top of the page. Know what they say; the note for each unit is in this guide.
- No one is ever asked to share their check-in, intention, cards, lament, confession, release, review, diagnosis, health or treatment.
- Leaders give no medical advice, and never suggest anyone start, stop or change medication.
- No one is ever asked to contact, confront or return to someone who harmed them. Forgiveness never replaces safeguarding or reporting.
- A voice others cannot hear, especially one giving commands or threats, is not to be assumed to be God: the person ends the retreat and seeks prompt assessment.
- Silence is never imposed, timed competitively, or interpreted for anyone.
- If a member says they are unsure what they believe, do not panic and do not argue. It is not a mental-health condition. Lesson 15 suggests who can help.

Using the online course in a group

- Each member watches the teaching on their own device, and does the lesson's step privately.
- The pages save almost nothing. The exceptions are a member's progress, the retreat plan confirmed on Session 1, and My Day 30 Review on Lesson 16. Each is visible only to that member; a leader cannot see them and should never ask to.

- The course page records the date a member completed their plan. It records participation only, never how well the retreat went. Never compare members' progress.

Notes for couples (Program 5)

The Retreat for Couples is two people taking the three-day retreat at the same time, in the same place, supporting each other. It is not a marriage-repair programme, and it is not a couples' counselling weekend. Each person does the personal work of the sessions alone. If the marriage needs repair, a retreat may help both come to that work with more capacity, but the work itself belongs to counselling.

Who should not use this plan

- If there is abuse, coercion or fear in the relationship, they should not take a retreat together. The person being harmed needs a safety plan and specialist support, not three days alone with the person harming them. If there is immediate danger, contact a domestic-abuse service or emergency services.
- If one partner is being pressured into the retreat by the other: the personal retreat separately, or not at all.
- If the relationship is in acute crisis: a qualified professional first, and consider separate retreats.

Before they begin

Each completes Part 2 individually. Then, together, they agree three things in writing: that the personal sessions are private, and neither will ask to read the other's journal or cards; how each will signal that they need space, without explanation; and what they will do if one needs to stop a session or the retreat. They agree the practicalities too, and use separate rooms or times for the sessions so that neither feels watched. Couples preparing for marriage arrange separate sleeping spaces consistent with their convictions and boundaries.

The three shared moments

When	What happens
End of Day 1, after Session 2 (20 minutes)	Each says one thing, and only one, they noticed today. The other listens without responding. Each prays one sentence for the other.
End of Day 2, after the break following Session 4 (20 minutes)	Each says one thing today was like. "I cannot talk tonight" is a complete answer. One sentence of prayer each. Do not ask about the lament, and do not offer to fix anything.
After Session 10 (up to an hour)	Each shares the rhythm they hope to establish and any practical action that will affect the marriage. Other cards are optional. They agree how to protect each other's rhythm, and read the blessing together.

Everything else stays private: the intention, confession, lament, release, identity and purpose cards, and the "What I sense" card. Privacy does not mean secrecy about immediate danger, abuse, serious misconduct, or anything that must be reported for someone's protection.

Notes for pastors and Christian leaders (Program 7)

Ministry burnout has features ordinary burnout does not. The work is bound up with faith, so exhaustion feels like spiritual failure. The role is bound up with identity, so weakness feels like disqualification. The person who would normally help, a pastor, is you. The pastors' plan is the three-day retreat with additions; Session 9 is recommended as the one flex session.

- **Who to tell.** Someone in leadership should know that the pastor is struggling, if they are. If no one in their own church can hear that safely: a pastor in another church, a denominational officer or a professional supervisor.
- **Location.** Not their own church building if at all possible. The retreat needs them to be nobody's pastor for three days.

- **Session 1.** The sermon, the meeting, the pastoral situation, the building project, the person who is angry with them: all of it goes in the envelope.
- **Session 3.** Ministers habitually mark everything Act. Watch the Share and Seek-counsel marks.
- **Session 4.** The ministry that did not become what they hoped, the people who left, the church that hurt them: give it a card.
- **Session 5.** Beware a confession that would sound right from a pulpit. If what surfaces involves misconduct, seek qualified guidance about accountability and reporting; do not manage it privately. Forgiveness and fellowship are not the same as return to office.
- **Session 7.** Bring your own question, not the church's. A personal impression does not bypass elders, boards, denominational oversight, or the church's ordinary processes.
- **Session 9.** Do it. "Do you love me?" asked of someone who has fed sheep professionally for years. Answer without the pulpit voice.
- **Session 10.** A weekly protected period of ceasing that the congregation knows about and a leadership team protects. For the one person: a supervisor or peer group outside the church.
- **Re-entry.** As a strong rule, do not preach or publicly announce what you believe you heard for at least a month. Let it be tested first.
- **When it is more than tiredness.** Find help outside your own church (Lesson 15).

Part 1 · Understand

Lessons 1 to 5, before the retreat.

Lesson 1: When Your Body Keeps Going but Your Soul Is Tired

Lesson 1 · Book chapter 1 · Part 1: Understand

"Why am I still tired after I have rested?"

Passage	1 Kings 19:3–8 and Matthew 11:28–30
Teaching	about 17 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Elijah under the broom tree (the course's central thread begins here)
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Start of the course

Aim for the meeting

Help the group see that soul-tiredness is common among faithful people, that God met Elijah with care before direction, and that the course is about availability to God, not about producing feelings.

Background for leaders

1 Kings 19 follows Elijah's greatest public moment: the contest on Carmel, fire from heaven, the end of the drought, and Elijah running ahead of Ahab's chariot to Jezreel (1 Kings 18:19–46). One message from Jezebel, and he runs for his life to Beersheba and then a day's journey into the wilderness, where he asks to die (19:1–4). Exhaustion often follows exertion; Scripture records it honestly.

God's response comes in an order the course will keep returning to: sleep, food and water, more sleep, more food, and only then a journey and a question (19:5–9). Elijah is described, not diagnosed: the lesson gives him no modern label, and leaders should not either.

Mark 6:30–32 shows the apostles back from their first mission, with "no leisure even to eat". Jesus' answer is an invitation to come away to a desolate place and rest. Matthew 11:28–30 widens the invitation to all who labour and are heavy laden.

Word note

erēmos (Greek, "desolate")

Used in Mark 6:31 ("to a desolate place") and Mark 1:35. A deserted or solitary place, away from the crowds. The word itself does not mean renewal: the rest comes from being with Jesus there, not from the place. Lessons 3 and 6 recall it.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. This is the first meeting. Welcome everyone, explain how the meetings will run, and state the rules for sharing. Say clearly that no one will be asked to read aloud, pray aloud or share their personal story, and that the leader is a facilitator, not a counsellor.

Discuss the passage. Read 1 Kings 19:3–8 and Matthew 11:28–30 aloud, then ask:

1. In 1 Kings 19:3–8, what does God do for Elijah, and in what order?

Leader's note: *He lets him sleep, sends an angel with a cake and water, lets him sleep again, feeds him a second time, and only then sends him on a journey (vv. 5–8). Care comes first; direction comes after.*

2. In Matthew 11:28–30, who is invited, and what is promised?

Leader's note: *All who labour and are heavy laden. Jesus promises rest for their souls, through coming to him and learning from him, the gentle and lowly one.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. What is the difference between being physically tired and soul-tired?

Leader's note: *Physical tiredness lifts with sleep; soul-tiredness can remain after the body has rested. Let people describe it in their own words; do not ask for examples from their lives.*

2. Why do you think God gave Elijah food and sleep before he gave him direction?

Leader's note: *Point back to the order of the passage. God did not begin with a rebuke or a task. Avoid suggesting that rest is a reward for good behaviour.*

3. A reset "is not a test of how spiritual you are." Why might that be important to hear? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Many people fear that needing rest means their faith is weak. The lesson says a reset is not a test of how spiritual you are; its goal is availability to God.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Answer the chapter's three questions privately and keep them for Session 10 and Day 30

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *If you are thinking about harming yourself or may be in danger, do not begin this retreat alone: contact emergency services or a crisis service and a trusted person now.*

Questions people may ask

Was Elijah depressed?
Scripture describes what happened to him honestly, but it does not give him a modern diagnosis, and neither does the course. If someone is asking about themselves, point gently to the lesson page's note and to Lesson 4.

Isn't tiredness just a lack of discipline?
Elijah had just served faithfully and fully. Jesus himself invited his tired disciples to rest. Needing rest is not weakness.

Extra Bible references

- **1 Kings 18:39, 46**: the fire on Carmel, and Elijah running to Jezreel
- **Mark 1:35**: Jesus rising early to pray in a desolate place
- **Luke 5:15–16**: he would withdraw to desolate places and pray
- **Psalm 127:2**: he gives to his beloved sleep

Don't miss this

- Soul-tiredness is common among faithful people. It does not make anyone a failure or a fraud.
- God met Elijah with care first (food, water and sleep, twice) before direction. The course honours that order: rest first, direction after.
- Jesus deliberately withdrew to pray and invited his tired disciples to rest. Needing rest is not weakness.
- A reset does not manufacture feelings, force God to speak or test anyone's spirituality. Its goal is availability to God.
- Elijah is described, not diagnosed. Scripture tells us honestly what happened; it does not give him a modern label.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he met Elijah with food and sleep before he gave him any task. Pray that each person will come to this course without pressure to perform, and that anyone who is tired in a place sleep does not reach will hear Jesus' invitation: "Come to me."

Lesson 2: Retreat Is Not Running Away

Lesson 2 · Book chapter 2 · Part 1: Understand

"Isn't it selfish to stop?"

Passage	Exodus 20:8–11 with Deuteronomy 5:15 · Luke 5:15–16
Teaching	about 18 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Jonah and Elijah, two men who fled
Christians differ	None in this lesson. Which day, and how the Sabbath command applies to Christians, is the one fair slide in Lesson 14; Slide 10 only points ahead to it
Builds on	Lesson 1 (Elijah under the broom tree; Luke 5:16; Matthew 11:28)

Aim for the meeting

Help the group see that God commanded rest and that rest declares he, not we, holds the world together; that a retreat withdraws in order to return; and that the lies which keep people from stopping can be named.

Background for leaders

The Sabbath command stands among the Ten Commandments, beside the commands against murder, theft and adultery, and it covers the whole household, servants, animals and the stranger (Exodus 20:8–11). Exodus grounds it in creation; Deuteronomy 5:15 grounds it in liberation: "remember that you were a slave". Rest belonged to a people God had set free.

Before Sinai, the manna taught the same lesson: a double portion on the sixth day, none on the seventh (Exodus 16:22–30). God's provision made obedience possible. Psalm 127:1–2 says the same about anxious toil.

Luke 5:15–16 recalls Jesus' habit of withdrawing (Lesson 1), and the lesson sets two men who fled beside each other: Jonah, fleeing in resistance (Jonah 1:3), and Elijah, fleeing in fear (1 Kings 19:3, 9). God dealt with both.

Word note

šāḇaṯ (Hebrew, "to cease")
The verb in Genesis 2:2: God rested, that is, ceased from his completed work. He was not recovering from exhaustion. Human rest includes recovery, but the word is about stopping. Exodus 20:11 uses a different verb (nûaḥ, to rest or settle), so the lesson teaches šāḇaṯ from Genesis 2:2 only. Lesson 14 recalls it.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Ask, in general terms only, whether anyone found it hard or helpful to answer Lesson 1's three questions. No one shares their answers.

Discuss the passage. Read Exodus 20:8–11 with Deuteronomy 5:15 · Luke 5:15–16 aloud, then ask:

1. Why does Exodus 20:11 give for the Sabbath, and why does Deuteronomy 5:15?

Leader's note: *Exodus: because God made heaven and earth in six days and rested on the seventh (creation). Deuteronomy: because Israel had been slaves in Egypt and the LORD brought them out (liberation).*

2. What does Luke 5:15–16 show Jesus doing when the crowds grew?

Leader's note: *He would withdraw to desolate places and pray, and then return to the people. He withdrew in order to return.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Why do you think God placed rest among the Ten Commandments, beside the commands against murder, theft and adultery?

Leader's note: *Rest is not an optional extra; it is set among the commands that protect life and relationships. It reminds us that God, not we, holds the world together.*

2. What is the difference between running away and retreating? What helps us recognise the difference between taking a healthy pause and avoiding something we need to face?

Leader's note: *Retreat is time with God with the intention of returning. Avoidance runs from what needs facing. Help people see that the question is whether we turn towards God honestly.*

3. Which of the three lies is most common where you live or work? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Keep this general: workplaces, churches, families. Do not ask anyone which lie they personally believe.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Write which of the three lies sounds most like you, and list what must be arranged, delegated, postponed or explained so you can step away responsibly

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *If someone depends on you for their safety or daily care, arrange that care before you step away. If you are in danger, or thinking about harming yourself, do not wait for a retreat: contact emergency services or a crisis service where you are, and a trusted person, now.*

Questions people may ask

Should Christians keep the Sabbath on Saturday or Sunday?
Christians differ. This lesson does not settle it: Lesson 14 has the one fair slide on which day and how the command applies. Here the point is that God commanded rest and that rest is good.

What about people who cannot stop, such as carers or those working several jobs?
The lesson says some people cannot stop because of circumstances outside their control, and need practical help, not only permission. A group can help with that.

Extra Bible references

- **Genesis 2:2–3**: God ceased from his work
- **Exodus 16:22–30**: the double portion and the seventh day
- **Psalm 127:1–2**: unless the LORD builds the house
- **Mark 2:27**: the Sabbath was made for man

Don't miss this

- God commanded rest for Israel within the covenant at Sinai, among the Ten Commandments and for the whole household. It reminds us that God, not we, holds the world together.
- šāḇaṯ means to cease. God did not rest because he was tired; human rest includes recovery, but the word is about stopping.
- Rest was part of the life of a people God had delivered (Deuteronomy 5:15). Some people cannot stop because of circumstances outside their control, and need practical help, not only permission.
- Jesus withdrew in order to return. A retreat is time with God with the intention of returning; its value does not depend on a dramatic change.
- Jonah fled in resistance, Elijah in fear, and God dealt with both. The question is whether we will turn towards God honestly and respond to what he shows us.
- Sabbath and retreat are not identical. Which day, and how Christians apply the Sabbath, is left for Lesson 14.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he commanded rest for a people he had set free. Pray for anyone who feels guilty about stopping, and for those who cannot stop without help, that the group and the church would help carry what needs carrying.

Lesson 3: Jesus and the Practice of Withdrawing

Lesson 3 · Book chapter 3 · Part 1: Understand

"How did Jesus rest, and what does that teach me?"

Passage	Mark 1:21–39 (read: 1:32–38) · Luke 6:12–13 · with Mark 14:32–36
Teaching	about 18 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Jesus after the day in Capernaum
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 2 (Luke 5:16: withdraw in order to return) · Lesson 1 (erēmos; Matthew 11:28)

Aim for the meeting

Help the group see how often Jesus withdrew, in what different circumstances, and why prayer was at the centre of it; and that solitude with God does not mean isolation from people.

Background for leaders

Mark 1:21–39 describes one day in Capernaum: teaching in the synagogue, a man delivered, Simon's mother-in-law healed, and "the whole city" at the door at sundown. Very early the next morning Jesus went out to a desolate place and prayed. When the disciples found him and said "Everyone is looking for you", he went on to the next towns.

The Gospels show Jesus away from the crowds after demand (Mark 1:35), in loss after John the Baptist's death (Matthew 14:13), before a decision (only Luke records the all-night prayer before choosing the Twelve, Luke 6:12–13), in testing (the forty days, Luke 4:1–2) and before suffering (Gethsemane, Mark 14:32–36).

Some of these were ordinary withdrawals for prayer. The forty days and Gethsemane belonged to unique moments in his mission: we are not asked to reproduce them, and no retreat of ours compares to Gethsemane.

Word note

erēmos (recalled) (Greek, "desolate")

No new word is taught. Slide 6 recalls erēmos from Lesson 1: Mark 1:35 and Matthew 14:13 use the same phrase, "a desolate place".

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Look back to Lesson 2: invite anyone who wishes to say, in general terms, whether arranging to step away has been easy or hard. No one names the lie they chose.

Discuss the passage. Read Mark 1:21–39 (read: 1:32–38) · Luke 6:12–13 · with Mark 14:32–36 aloud, then ask:

1. In Mark 1:32–38, what had happened the evening before Jesus went out to pray?

Leader's note: *The whole city gathered at the door, and he healed many and cast out many demons. He withdrew after a day of great demand.*

2. When the disciples interrupted him, what did he do?

Leader's note: *He did not scold them or stay; he said, "Let us go on to the next towns" (v. 38). Interruptions do not ruin a retreat; he responded and returned to his purpose.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. The Gospels show Jesus away from the crowds after demand, in loss, before a decision, in testing and before suffering. Which of these surprises you most, and why?

Leader's note: *Many people expect that solitude is only for calm or spiritual moods. Jesus withdrew in loss, before decisions and before suffering.*

2. Why do you think Christian retreats can drift towards being mainly about calm and wellness? What changes when the centre is time with the Father?

Leader's note: *The centre of a Christian retreat is time with the Father, not wellness. Calm may come, but it is not the goal.*

3. How can we tell the difference between a genuine need and an avoidable distraction? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Compassion does not mean answering every demand at once. Keep examples general.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Name which of the five moments is closest to you, and why; name one trustworthy person you will tell about your retreat

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *If solitude brings up grief or pain that feels too heavy to carry alone, speak with someone you trust before you go further. If you are in danger, or thinking about harming yourself, contact emergency services or a crisis service, and a trusted person, now.*

Questions people may ask

Should I try to fast for forty days like Jesus?

No. The forty days belonged to a unique moment in his mission. Lesson 10 explains that this retreat does not require fasting.

What if I have no one to tell about my retreat?

Where possible, each learner lets one trustworthy person know; but completing the lesson never depends on someone else being available. Help them think of a pastor, a friend or a support service.

Extra Bible references

- **Matthew 14:13–14, 23**: he withdrew after John's death, then had compassion
- **Luke 9:28–32**: prayer on the mountain
- **John 17**: Jesus' prayer for his disciples
- **Hebrews 5:7**: loud cries and tears in the days of his flesh

Don't miss this

- The Gospels show Jesus away from the crowds after demand, in loss, before a decision, in testing and before suffering. Some were deliberate withdrawals for prayer; the wilderness and Gethsemane belonged to unique moments in his mission. There was no single mood that qualified him for solitude.
- Prayer was central to his life and ministry, and where Scripture records his prayers they are remarkably honest. Not every withdrawal states its purpose. We withdraw to become present to God, not merely to become calmer.
- The forty days in the wilderness and Gethsemane were unique to Christ. We are not asked to reproduce them, and no retreat of ours compares to Gethsemane.
- Interruptions do not ruin a retreat. Respond to genuine needs and return; but compassion does not mean answering every demand at once.
- Solitude with God is essential; unhealthy isolation from people is not the goal. Where possible, each learner lets at least one trustworthy person know about the retreat; completing the lesson never depends on someone else being available.

Close in prayer

Thank God that Jesus prayed honestly in every kind of moment. Pray that each person will find time with the Father, not merely calm, and will have at least one trustworthy person who knows they are stepping away.

Lesson 4: Recognising Burnout, Spiritual Dryness, and Emotional Overload

Lesson 4 · Book chapter 4 · Part 1: Understand

"What is actually happening to me?"

Passage	Exodus 18:13–23 (with Numbers 11:10–17) · Psalm 42:1–3 (with Psalm 13:1) · 2 Corinthians 1:8–9
Teaching	about 18 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Moses and Jethro
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lessons 1–3 (Elijah, rest and withdrawal); Look back to Lesson 1, as the design says

Aim for the meeting

Help the group recognise burnout, spiritual dryness and emotional overload as pastoral descriptions, not diagnoses; see that Jethro's answer to Moses was a shared load; and know when to ask for more help.

Background for leaders

In Exodus 18:13–23 Jethro watches Moses judging the people from morning to evening and says, "What you are doing is not good… you are not able to do it alone." His answer is structural: share the load with capable people. In Numbers 11:10–17, a separate event, God himself appoints seventy elders to bear the burden with Moses. Moses is described, not diagnosed.

Psalm 42 and Psalm 13 pray honestly when God seems far away. Dryness is not always the result of sin: Psalm 32 shows unconfessed sin weighing heavily, but Job shows suffering that is not punishment, so both belong in the picture. Psalm 88 ends without visible relief, and it is in Scripture.

Paul writes that in Asia he and his companions were "so utterly burdened beyond our strength that we despaired of life itself" (2 Corinthians 1:8–9). The apostle did not hide it.

Word note

This lesson teaches no Greek or Hebrew word, as the course design says. Keep the focus on what the passages say.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. The look back card goes back to Lesson 1: invite people to remember, privately, the three questions they answered. No one shares them.

Discuss the passage. Read Exodus 18:13–23 (with Numbers 11:10–17) · Psalm 42:1–3 (with Psalm 13:1) · 2 Corinthians 1:8–9 aloud, then ask:

1. What did Jethro say to Moses, and why?

Leader's note: *"What you are doing is not good. You and the people with you will certainly wear yourselves out… you are not able to do it alone" (Exodus 18:17–18). He advised choosing capable people to share the load.*

2. In Psalm 13, what does David do with his sense of God's absence?

Leader's note: *He brings it to God: "How long, O LORD?" He asks to be answered, and ends with trust in God's steadfast love (vv. 5–6).*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Jethro's answer to Moses was structural, not "try harder". Where do you see people trying to carry alone what should be shared?

Leader's note: *Rest alone does not fix a structure that is too heavy. Keep examples general: workplaces, churches, families.*

2. Why do you think Scripture keeps prayers like Psalm 13 and Psalm 88? How might they help someone who feels far from God?

Leader's note: *These prayers show that honesty with God is faithful, not faithless. They give words to people who have none.*

3. Why is it unhelpful to explain every struggle as either purely spiritual or purely medical? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *We are whole people. Some struggles have spiritual, emotional and physical causes at once; seeking medical help is not a lack of faith. Do not invite people to describe their symptoms.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). The book's personal check-in: mark the signs that describe the past month (private, not scored) and answer its four questions. Keep them for Session 1.

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *If low mood, emptiness or loss of interest has been present most days for two weeks or more, or is affecting your work, sleep, eating or relationships, please speak with a doctor or mental-health professional. If you may be in immediate danger, stop here and make that contact now.*

The book's personal check-in is private and not scored. Leaders never ask anyone to share it.

Questions people may ask

How do I know if this is depression rather than burnout?
The lesson cannot tell them apart, and neither can a group leader. The page note says: if low mood, emptiness or loss of interest has been present most days for two weeks or more, or is affecting work, sleep, eating or relationships, speak with a doctor or mental-health professional.

Isn't dryness always caused by unconfessed sin?
No. Sometimes sin plays a part (Psalm 32), but Job and the lament psalms show dryness and distress that are not punishment.

Extra Bible references

- **Numbers 11:14–17**: the seventy elders
- **Psalm 42:1–3**: as a deer pants for flowing streams
- **Psalm 88**: a lament that ends in darkness
- **1 Peter 5:7**: casting all your anxieties on him

Don't miss this

- These are pastoral descriptions, not diagnoses. They overlap, and the lesson cannot tell depression, anxiety, stress or illness apart from them.
- The answer to Moses' burden was structural: Jethro advised shared responsibility (Exodus 18:22), and later God himself appointed seventy elders (Numbers 11:17). These are two separate events. Moses is described, not diagnosed.
- Dryness is not always the result of sin (Psalm 32 and Job both belong in the picture). The retreat cannot force God to feel close.
- Psalm 88 is in Scripture: not every lament ends in visible relief.
- Seeking help is not a lack of faith. The note on the page is read by everyone, and immediate safety comes before the retreat.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he hears honest prayer when he seems far away. Pray that anyone carrying too much will find people to share the load, and that anyone who needs more help will have the courage to ask for it.

Lesson 5: What a Retreat Can and Cannot Do

Lesson 5 · Book chapter 5 · Part 1: Understand

"What can I honestly hope for?"

Passage	Galatians 6:1–2 · Proverbs 11:14 (with Luke 5:31 and Colossians 4:14)
Teaching	about 15 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Elijah, who slept and ate twice before God spoke
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 4 (separating hope from expectation; help); Look back to Lesson 4, as the design says

Aim for the meeting

Help the group hold honest hope for the retreat without turning it into a transaction; see that seeking help is not a lack of faith; and understand that postponing is not failing.

Background for leaders

Galatians 6:1–2 assumes that some burdens are too heavy to carry alone: "Bear one another's burdens, and so fulfill the law of Christ." Proverbs 11:14 adds that "in an abundance of counselors there is safety."

Paul calls Luke "the beloved physician" (Colossians 4:14), and gave Timothy practical advice about his stomach and frequent ailments (1 Timothy 5:23, described, not quoted, in the lesson). Jesus said that those who are sick need a physician (Luke 5:31). Early Christians did not set faith against ordinary means of care.

Elijah slept and ate twice before God spoke to him (1 Kings 19:5–8). The lesson also introduces the book's word about hearing from God: impressions are held lightly and tested later, in Lesson 12.

Word note

This lesson teaches no Greek or Hebrew word: the passages are clear in English.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. The look back card goes back to Lesson 4. Invite people to recall, privately, the check-in they completed. No one shares it.

Discuss the passage. Read Galatians 6:1–2 · Proverbs 11:14 (with Luke 5:31 and Colossians 4:14) aloud, then ask:

1. What does Galatians 6:1–2 assume about burdens?

Leader's note: *That some are too heavy to carry alone, and that believers are meant to help carry them. Restoring someone is done gently, watching ourselves.*

2. What does Proverbs 11:14 say about counsel?

Leader's note: *Where there is no guidance a people falls, but in an abundance of counselors there is safety.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Why do you think some Christians feel that seeking counselling or medication is a failure of faith? How does this lesson answer that?

Leader's note: *Let the group name the fear in general terms. The lesson answers it with Luke, Paul's advice to Timothy, and Proverbs.*

2. Which of the five things a retreat cannot do do people most often expect from it?

Leader's note: *Most often: to fix in days what took years, or to guarantee a felt sense of God. Naming the expectation helps people hold it lightly.*

3. Why might pausing a session be a faithful choice rather than a failure? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Pausing to rest, ground oneself or seek help is wisdom. Postponing is not failing.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Choose one of the four paths, name the person you will call if a session becomes too much, and separate what you are asking of God from what you expect the retreat to produce

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *Some situations need support before or during a retreat: thoughts of not wanting to be alive, abuse, dependence on alcohol or sedatives, trauma reactions, or medical advice not to be alone. Postponing is not failing.*

The page note lists situations that need support before or during a retreat: thoughts of not wanting to be alive, abuse, dependence on alcohol or sedatives, trauma reactions, or medical advice not to be alone. Know the four paths the lesson offers (proceed independently, proceed with support, use an adapted plan, postpone).

Questions people may ask

If I take medication, can I still do the retreat?
Yes. Lesson 10 says to bring medication and not to change doses or routines for the retreat without medical advice. A leader never gives advice about medication.

What if God shows me something big on retreat?
Hold it lightly and test it later (Lesson 12). No irreversible decisions during the retreat unless immediate safety requires it.

Extra Bible references

- **Luke 5:31**: those who are sick need a physician
- **Colossians 4:14**: Luke the beloved physician
- **1 Kings 19:5–8**: Elijah fed twice
- **Psalm 88**: God kept the prayer that ends in darkness

Don't miss this

- A retreat can be a real beginning, but it is not a transaction. God is not summoned by a schedule.
- A retreat cannot replace medical or psychological care, fix in three days what took years, guarantee a felt sense of God, replace community, or make decisions for anyone.
- Seeking help is not a lack of faith. Paul calls Luke the beloved physician; Paul gave Timothy practical health advice; God works through ordinary means.
- Impressions are held lightly and tested later (Lesson 12). No irreversible decisions during the retreat unless immediate safety requires it.
- Postponing is not failing. Anyone in danger is helped to safety first; the retreat can wait.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he works through people and ordinary means. Pray for anyone who needs support before or during the retreat, that they will find it, and that anyone who needs to postpone will do so without shame.

Part 2 · Prepare

Lessons 6 to 11, before the retreat. Lessons 7 and 9 must be done before anyone comes.

Lesson 6: Choosing Your Retreat Length and Location

Lesson 6 · Book chapter 6 · Part 2: Prepare

"How long, and where?"

Passage	Mark 6:30–32 · Genesis 24:63
Teaching	about 17 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Jesus and the disciples by boat to a desolate place
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 3 (ordinary places; interruptions) and Lesson 5 (the four paths); Look back to both, as the design says

Aim for the meeting

Help the group see that a retreat needs to be protected, not elaborate; that the right length is the one you can protect; and that each place is tested for safety and access to help.

Background for leaders

Mark 6:30–32 shows the apostles back from their first mission (Mark 6:7–13), so busy that they had no leisure even to eat. Jesus' invitation is simple: "Come away by yourselves to a desolate place and rest a while." They went by boat to an empty shore, and the crowds ran ahead of them (6:33–34).

Genesis 24:63 shows Isaac going out to the field toward evening. The Hebrew verb is uncertain ("meditate" or "walk"), and the lesson does not teach it; the picture is of an ordinary place.

Jesus withdrew to ordinary places (Lesson 3). The most important elements of a retreat are free: time, a door that closes, a Bible, a notebook.

Word note

No word is taught. The lesson only mentions that "desolate place" is the word met in Lessons 1 and 3 (erēmos), and that the verb in Genesis 24:63 is uncertain.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. The look back cards go to Lessons 3 and 5: the ordinary places Jesus withdrew to, and the four paths. People recall which path they chose, privately.

Discuss the passage. Read Mark 6:30–32 · Genesis 24:63 aloud, then ask:

1. What did Jesus invite the apostles to do, and why?

Leader's note: *To come away by themselves to a desolate place and rest a while, because many were coming and going and they had no leisure even to eat (Mark 6:31).*

2. What happened when they arrived?

Leader's note: *The crowd had run ahead of them. Jesus had compassion on them. Interruptions happen even to good plans.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Why do you think so many people want time with God but never create it?

Leader's note: *Busyness, guilt, cost, and the sense that one must earn rest. Keep it general.*

2. Which of the seven questions is hardest for you to answer "yes" to, and what might help?

Leader's note: *The seven questions include safety, sleep and access to help. Encourage practical problem-solving, not confession.*

3. How could a family, a church or a group of friends help someone take a retreat? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Families, churches and friends can offer childcare, cover, a borrowed room, or a lift.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Decide length, place, the seven questions and dates (at least a format and a target month), and choose a Retreat Plan with the plan guide on the page

Safety and care

This lesson page has no separate safety note. The rules for sharing and "When someone is in trouble" apply as always.

Questions people may ask

Is a three-hour reset really enough?

It is an immediate pause, not the full retreat and not crisis care. A one-day retreat that happens is worth more than a three-day retreat that never does; longer is not automatically better.

Do I need to go away to a retreat centre?

No. The most important elements are free. Every place is tested with seven questions, including safety, sleep and access to help.

Extra Bible references

- **Mark 6:7–13**: the first mission
- **Mark 6:33–34**: the crowds ran ahead; he had compassion
- **1 Kings 19:5**: Elijah slept
- **Luke 5:16**: he would withdraw to desolate places

Don't miss this

- A retreat does not need to be elaborate. It needs to be protected. The most important elements are free.
- Choose the length you can protect: three days is recommended, but a one-day retreat that happens is worth more than a three-day retreat that never does.
- The three-hour reset is an immediate pause, not the full retreat and not crisis care. Longer is not automatically better.
- Every place is tested with seven questions, including safety, sleep and access to help. Solitude does not mean placing yourself beyond the reach of help.
- The Retreat Plans are offered, not assigned; a session left for later is not a missing requirement.

Close in prayer

Thank God for Jesus' simple invitation to come away and rest a while. Pray that each person will find a length and a place they can protect, and people to help make it possible.

Lesson 7: Setting Your Intention

Lesson 7 · Book chapter 7 · Part 2: Prepare

"What do I actually want to bring to God?"

Passage	Mark 10:46–52 · Psalm 27:4 (with 1 Samuel 1:9–18)
Teaching	about 18 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Bartimaeus; Hannah
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 5 (separating what we ask of God from what we expect the retreat to produce), as the design says; also uses the Lesson 4 check-in

Aim for the meeting

Help the group understand what an intention is: one honest sentence to God, held with open hands, provisional and allowed to change.

Background for leaders

Bartimaeus sat by the road at Jericho, the last stop before the climb to Jerusalem (Mark 10:32–34). The crowd tried to silence him; he cried out all the more. Jesus stopped and asked, "What do you want me to do for you?"

Just before, Jesus had asked James and John the same question (Mark 10:36), and it exposed a very different desire: to sit at his right and left in glory. The same question can reveal very different hearts.

Hannah, at Shiloh, poured out her soul before the LORD so honestly that Eli thought she was drunk (1 Samuel 1:9–18). Psalm 27:4 gathers many concerns into one: "One thing have I asked of the LORD." Gethsemane's "not what I will, but what you will" (Mark 14:36) is the pattern of open hands.

Word note

This lesson teaches no Greek or Hebrew word, as the course design says.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Look back to Lesson 5: the difference between what we ask of God and what we expect the retreat to produce. Invite general comments only.

Discuss the passage. Read Mark 10:46–52 · Psalm 27:4 (with 1 Samuel 1:9–18) aloud, then ask:

1. Why might Jesus ask a blind man what he wanted, when the answer seemed obvious?

Leader's note: *The question invited Bartimaeus to name his desire before God. It treated him as a person, not a problem.*

2. How did Hannah pray, and how was she misjudged?

Leader's note: *She poured out her soul, praying in her heart so that only her lips moved. Eli thought she was drunk; she explained she was troubled in spirit (1 Samuel 1:13–16).*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Why do you think Jesus asked a blind man what he wanted?

Leader's note: *Naming a desire honestly is part of faith. Let the group reflect without sharing their own requests.*

2. Which is harder for you: gathering many concerns into one, or saying it honestly instead of politely?

Leader's note: *Some people have too many concerns; others are too polite. Both are common.*

3. What helps you hold a request to God with open hands? Share your own experience only if you wish; no one needs to share their intention.

Leader's note: *Open hands is a request, not a demand. It never means passivity towards abuse, injustice or danger, or giving up wisdom, boundaries or safety. No one shares their intention.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Write the four-part intention: what I am carrying, what I am asking, what I have not said, what I am releasing

Safety and care

This lesson page has no separate safety note. The rules for sharing and "When someone is in trouble" apply as always.

Questions people may ask

What if I cannot find an intention?

The lesson offers a way in: what I am carrying, what I am asking, what I have not said, what I am releasing. The intention is allowed to be simple, and allowed to change.

Is it selfish to ask God for something for myself?

Jesus asked Bartimaeus what he wanted. Hidden hopes are named, not judged; motives need not be perfectly pure.

Extra Bible references

- **Psalm 27:4**: one thing have I asked
- **Psalm 139:23–24**: search me, O God
- **Jeremiah 29:13**: you will seek me and find me
- **Mark 14:36**: not what I will, but what you will

Don't miss this

- An intention is one honest sentence to God about what you are bringing and what you are asking. It is provisional, not controlling.
- Jesus' question made Bartimaeus name his desire; the same question exposed a very different desire in James and John.
- One thing, not a list: the desire underneath the others. The intention is allowed to change.
- Honest, not polished: Hannah poured out her soul. Hidden hopes are named, not judged; motives need not be perfectly pure.
- Open hands: a request, not a demand. This never means passivity towards abuse, injustice or danger, or giving up wisdom, boundaries or safety.
- No one is asked to share their intention in a group.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he asks us what we want and listens. Pray that each person will be able to say one honest sentence to him, and hold it with open hands.

Lesson 8: Preparing Your Heart

Lesson 8 · Book chapter 8 · Part 2: Prepare

"How do I get ready inside, not only outside?"

Passage	Psalm 131 · Matthew 5:23–24
Teaching	about 19 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	The weaned child
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 7 (the intention), as the design says; also Lessons 4 (Jethro; dryness not always sin) and 5 (the four paths; safety)

Aim for the meeting

Help the group begin preparing inwardly: a settled nearness to God like the weaned child, a seven-psalm week, noticing resistance without dramatising it, and addressing what can safely be addressed before the retreat.

Background for leaders

Psalm 131 is one of the Songs of Ascents (Psalms 120–134), sung on the way up to Jerusalem. The psalmist has calmed and quieted his soul "like a weaned child with its mother": a child no longer coming only to be fed, but content to stay near.

In Matthew 5:23–24, Jesus says that if you remember a brother has something against you, you should go and be reconciled first. The lesson applies this particularly to wrongs we have genuinely committed, while making clear that no one is required to contact an unsafe person. Forgiveness and reconciliation are not the same thing.

Jehoshaphat "set his face to seek the LORD" (2 Chronicles 20:3), and Jethro's handover (Exodus 18:17–23) shows that preparing well includes handing responsibilities to others.

Word note

dāmam (Hebrew, "quieted")

Psalm 131:2: to become still or silent. The verb is active: the psalmist quieted his own soul. Lesson 11 returns to the same family of words (dûmiyyâ, Psalm 62:1).

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Look back to Lesson 7. Invite anyone who wishes to say, in general terms, what writing an intention was like. No one shares their intention.

Discuss the passage. Read Psalm 131 · Matthew 5:23–24 aloud, then ask:

1. What picture does Psalm 131 use, and what does it suggest?

Leader's note: *A weaned child with its mother: calm and quiet, near without demanding. It suggests contentment in God's presence, not only receiving from him.*

2. What does Matthew 5:23–24 ask, and what does the lesson add?

Leader's note: *To be reconciled before bringing a gift. The lesson adds that this applies particularly to wrongs we have genuinely committed, and that no one is required to contact an unsafe person.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. What does the picture of a weaned child, content to stay near, say to you about being with God?

Leader's note: *Let people say what the image suggests to them, without pressing for personal stories.*

2. What forms does resistance usually take for you when you try to slow down?

Leader's note: *Resistance is information, not a command, and not every distraction is spiritual opposition. Do not ask anyone to name their resistance.*

3. How could a church or a group of friends help someone hand over well and be prayed for during a retreat? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Practical help: cover, meals, a written handover, people praying on each retreat day.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Begin the seven-psalm week, notice resistance, address what can safely be addressed, hand over responsibilities in writing, and ask one person to pray for you on each retreat day

Safety and care

This lesson page has no separate safety note. The rules for sharing and "When someone is in trouble" apply as always.

Questions people may ask

Do I have to confess everything before the retreat?
Confess what you know, and leave the rest to God. Deeper confession has its own unhurried space in Session 5. Scrupulosity needs gentle, qualified help, not more rules.

What if I cannot prepare properly before I go?
The retreat can still be taken honestly. A restless retreat is not a failed one.

Extra Bible references

- **Psalm 62**: for God alone my soul waits in silence
- **Psalm 32:5**: I acknowledged my sin to you
- **1 John 1:9**: if we confess our sins, he is faithful
- **James 5:16**: pray for one another

Don't miss this

- A retreat begins in the days before. If preparation is not possible, the retreat can still be taken honestly; a restless retreat is not a failed one.
- dāmam: the psalmist actively quieted his soul. The weaned child stays near, content, not only to receive.
- Resistance is information, not a command. Not every distraction is spiritual opposition.
- Matthew 5:23–24 describes someone having something against us. The lesson applies this particularly to wrongs we have genuinely committed, while making clear that no one is required to contact an unsafe person. Forgiveness and reconciliation are not the same thing.
- Confess what you know, and leave the rest to God; private confession never replaces safeguarding, reporting or accountability. Scrupulosity needs gentle, qualified help.
- In a group, no one is asked to name a relationship, a sin, or their resistance.

Close in prayer

Thank God that we can come near to him like a child content with its mother. Pray that each person will be able to address what can safely be addressed, hand over well, and be prayed for on each retreat day.

Lesson 9: Creating a Digital Boundary, and What to Bring

Lesson 9 · Book chapters 9 and 10 · Part 2: Prepare

"How do I protect these days without cutting myself off from help?"

Passage	Luke 10:38–42 · 1 Corinthians 6:12 (with 2 Timothy 4:13)
Teaching	about 20 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Martha and Mary
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 6 (the four ordinary questions, including the phone), as the design says; also Lessons 5 (safety; emergency calling), 2 (guilt about leaving), and 4, 7 and 8 (the pages to bring)

Aim for the meeting

Help the group plan a digital boundary that protects attention for God and never becomes a barrier to help, and pack what they need for the sessions, the body and safety.

Background for leaders

In Luke 10:38–42, Martha welcomes Jesus into her home; Mary sits at his feet as a learner. Martha is "distracted with much serving". Her service was good: the issue was being drawn away in that moment. "One thing is necessary."

"All things are lawful for me" (1 Corinthians 6:12) is probably a Corinthian saying that Paul answers: "but not all things are helpful… I will not be dominated by anything."

Paul in prison asks Timothy to bring his cloak and his books, especially the parchments (2 Timothy 4:13). Ordinary things matter.

Word note

perispaō (Greek, "was distracted")

Luke 10:40 (periespato, imperfect passive): she was being drawn away. It describes Martha's attention in that moment, not a modern psychological condition. Her service itself was good.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Look back to Lesson 6: the four ordinary questions, including the phone. Invite general comments on what planning has been like.

Discuss the passage. Read Luke 10:38–42 · 1 Corinthians 6:12 (with 2 Timothy 4:13) aloud, then ask:

1. What was Martha doing, and what did Jesus say about it?

Leader's note: *She was distracted with much serving and asked Jesus to tell Mary to help. He answered gently that she was anxious and troubled about many things, and that one thing is necessary (vv. 41–42).*

2. How does Paul answer "All things are lawful for me"?

Leader's note: *Not all things are helpful, and he will not be dominated by anything (1 Corinthians 6:12).*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Where do you see good and legitimate things crowding out attentive presence in your own life?

Leader's note: *Good and legitimate things can crowd out attention. Keep it general.*

2. Which arrangement would suit you best, and what would make it hard to keep?

Leader's note: *The two arrangements do not combine. Each person decides their own; test before going; define "emergency" together with whoever needs to reach them.*

3. How could a family or group help each other keep a digital boundary without monitoring or shaming? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Encourage without monitoring, shaming or confiscating devices.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Fill in the written digital agreement, test the emergency-contact arrangement before you go, and tick the packing checklist

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *Keep emergency calling available: a boundary against distraction is never a boundary against help. Test the arrangement before you go.*

The book's packing list includes medication and aids. Members do not change doses or routines for the retreat without medical advice.

Questions people may ask

What if someone needs to reach me in an emergency?
Emergency calling stays available in every arrangement. A boundary against distraction is never a boundary against help.

What if I check my phone during the retreat?
A slip is noticed, not failed. The boundary is not a willpower test or a spiritual achievement.

Extra Bible references

- **Luke 10:38–42**: Martha and Mary
- **Psalm 119:37**: turn my eyes from looking at worthless things
- **2 Timothy 4:13**: bring the cloak and the books
- **Mark 1:35**: a desolate place, early in the morning

Don't miss this

- The boundary protects attention for God; it is not a willpower test or a spiritual achievement. A slip is noticed, not failed.
- It is never a boundary against help: emergency calling stays available in every arrangement.
- perispaō: Martha was being drawn away. Her service was good; distraction in that moment was the issue. No modern diagnosis is implied.
- Two arrangements, and they do not combine. Test before you go; define "emergency" together.
- Bring medication and aids; do not change doses or routines for the retreat without medical advice.
- In a group: each person states their own boundary. Encourage without monitoring, shaming or confiscating devices.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he welcomes our attention. Pray that each person's boundary will protect time with him, and that every arrangement will keep help within reach.

Lesson 10: Fasting, Food, Rest, and Physical Health

Lesson 10 · Book chapter 11 · Part 2: Prepare

"How does caring for my body belong to meeting God?"

Passage	1 Kings 19:5–8 · Psalm 127:2 (with Matthew 6:16–18 and Isaiah 58)
Teaching	about 17 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Elijah fed twice
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 1 (Elijah) and Lesson 9 (what to bring), as the design says; also Lessons 3 (Jesus' forty days), 5 (dependence and support) and 6 (arriving exhausted)

Aim for the meeting

Help the group see that caring for the body belongs to meeting God: ordinary eating is the default, sleep is a gift, and fasting is never required.

Background for leaders

In 1 Kings 19:5–8 the angel wakes Elijah twice to eat: "Arise and eat, for the journey is too great for you." Care for the body comes first in his story. Psalm 127:2: "he gives to his beloved sleep."

Fasting in Scripture is real, but it is done without display (Matthew 6:16–18), sometimes before decisions (Acts 13:2–3), and is empty without justice (Isaiah 58). Jesus' forty days are not a model for this retreat.

Jesus slept in the storm (Mark 4:38), cooked breakfast for his disciples on the beach (John 21:9–13), and was known in the breaking of bread at Emmaus (Luke 24:30–31).

Word note

This lesson teaches no Greek or Hebrew word, as the course design says.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Look back to Lesson 9. Invite general comments on testing the phone arrangement. No one shares their plan.

Discuss the passage. Read 1 Kings 19:5–8 · Psalm 127:2 (with Matthew 6:16–18 and Isaiah 58) aloud, then ask:

1. What did the angel say to Elijah, and what did it lead to?

Leader's note: *"Arise and eat, for the journey is too great for you." He ate and drank, and went in the strength of that food forty days and forty nights to Horeb (1 Kings 19:7–8).*

2. What does Psalm 127:2 say about sleep?

Leader's note: *It is in vain to rise up early and go late to rest, eating the bread of anxious toil; for he gives to his beloved sleep.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Why do you think God cared for Elijah's body before giving him the journey?

Leader's note: *God cared for Elijah's body before giving him the journey. Care is not a distraction from meeting God.*

2. Which do you find harder to receive as a gift: food, sleep, or rest?

Leader's note: *Let people reflect privately; some find sleep hardest to receive. Do not ask about anyone's eating or health.*

3. How could a group plan meals and rest for a retreat so that no one feels pressure to fast or to push through tiredness? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Plan meals and rest together so that no one feels pressure to fast or push through tiredness.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Write a simple meal plan, your sleep and wake times, and any safe movement. The default is ordinary eating.

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *Ordinary eating is the default. This course does not recommend food fasting for anyone with a current or past eating disorder, and do not stop alcohol or sedatives suddenly without medical advice.*

The lesson never gives targets or amounts for food, fluid or fasting. Never restrict water; stop any fast at concerning symptoms; do not stop alcohol or sedatives suddenly if you may be dependent. A leader never comments on anyone's eating, weight or health.

Questions people may ask

Should I fast on the retreat?
The retreat does not require fasting, and every session has full benefit without it. Who should not fast without medical guidance is listed on the page; and without exception, no food fasting for anyone with a current or past eating disorder.

Is it unspiritual to sleep during a retreat?
Sleep is a gift, not an interruption. Elijah slept twice before God spoke.

Extra Bible references

- **Matthew 6:16–18**: fasting without display
- **Isaiah 58:6–7**: the fast that God chooses
- **John 21:9–13**: breakfast on the beach
- **Psalm 139:14**: fearfully and wonderfully made

Don't miss this

- The default is ordinary eating. The retreat does not require fasting, and every session has full benefit without it.
- Elijah was fed twice before the journey; care for the body comes first in his story.
- Who should not fast without medical guidance; and, without exception, no food fasting for anyone with a current or past eating disorder.
- Never restrict water; stop any fast at concerning symptoms; do not stop alcohol suddenly if you may be dependent.
- Sleep is a gift, not an interruption. Walk, do not train.
- In a group, no one is asked about their eating, health or fasting, and no meal plan is shared aloud.

Close in prayer

Thank God for food, sleep and rest as his gifts. Pray that each person will care for their body without guilt or pressure, and that anyone who needs medical guidance will seek it.

Lesson 11: What to Do When You Are Afraid of Silence

Lesson 11 · Book chapter 12 · Part 2: Prepare

"What if silence frightens me, or nothing happens?"

Passage	Psalm 62:1–2, 5 · Job 2:13 (with Lamentations 3:26–28)
Teaching	about 19 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Job's friends, silent for seven days
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 8 (dāmam; three minutes of quiet), as the design says; also Lessons 5 (safety; grounding), 7 (the intention as something to hold) and 9 (the digital boundary)

Aim for the meeting

Help the group see that fear of silence is common and not a sign of weak faith; that silence is attention, not emptiness; and how to start small and stay safe.

Background for leaders

Psalm 62 alternates silence and speech: "For God alone my soul waits in silence" (v. 1), and then "pour out your heart before him" (v. 8). Silence before God is not the absence of honest words.

Job's friends sat with him on the ground seven days and seven nights, and no one spoke, "for they saw that his suffering was very great" (Job 2:13). Their silent presence helped him more than their later speeches.

Lamentations 3:26–28, written after Jerusalem's fall, says it is good to wait quietly for the salvation of the LORD. Waiting quietly before God is not silence about harm.

Word note

dûmiyyâ (Hebrew, "in silence")

Psalm 62:1: quiet waiting, related to dāmam, the verb from Lesson 8. Psalm 62:5 uses dōmmî, an imperative form of the verb ("wait in silence").

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Look back to Lesson 8: the three minutes of quiet each day. What happened in those minutes, in general terms? Let that, not an ideal, decide anyone's starting length.

Discuss the passage. Read Psalm 62:1–2, 5 · Job 2:13 (with Lamentations 3:26–28) aloud, then ask:

1. In Psalm 62, what does the psalmist do in silence, and what does he do with words?

Leader's note: *He waits for God alone in silence (vv. 1, 5), and he calls the people to trust God and pour out their hearts before him (v. 8).*

2. What did Job's friends do first, and why?

Leader's note: *They sat with him on the ground seven days and seven nights without speaking, because they saw that his suffering was very great (Job 2:13).*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Why do you think silence feels like relief to some people and like a threat to others?

Leader's note: *Silence feels different for different people. Fear of it is not weak faith.*

2. What might Job's friends teach us about being present to someone who is suffering?

Leader's note: *Presence often helps more than words. This is also a lesson for how the group treats one another.*

3. Which form of silence (still, moving or supported) would help you most to begin? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Three forms: still, moving, supported. None is more spiritual. Each person chooses their own.*

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Choose your starting length and form of silence (still, moving or supported) and write your first anchor phrase on a card for your Bible. Then complete the Before My Retreat page.

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *If silence brings panic, a sense of reliving the past or unreality, stop, open your eyes and orient yourself. If you hear a voice others cannot hear, especially one giving commands, end the retreat and seek prompt professional assessment.*

If anyone hears a voice others cannot hear, especially one giving commands, they end the retreat and seek prompt professional assessment. Lesson 11 ends with the Before My Retreat page, which is private and saves nothing.

Questions people may ask

What if nothing happens in the silence?
You have not failed. The waiting itself is prayer, and sensing nothing is a complete outcome.

What if silence makes me panic?
Stop, open your eyes and orient yourself. The silence is always adjustable. Know the difference between discomfort and distress.

Extra Bible references

- **Psalm 62:8**: pour out your heart before him
- **Lamentations 3:26–28**: good to wait quietly
- **Psalm 46:10**: be still, and know that I am God (with its original setting)
- **1 Kings 19:12**: the sound of a low whisper (Session 7)

Don't miss this

- The fear of silence is common and is not a sign of weak faith. The silence is always adjustable.
- Silence is attention, not emptiness, and it does not require soundlessness or stillness. Three forms: still, moving, supported; none is more spiritual.
- Start small: one to five minutes. Ten attentive minutes can be a complete practice.
- Know the difference between discomfort and distress. A voice others cannot hear is not to be assumed to be God: end the retreat and seek assessment.
- If you sense nothing, you have not failed. The waiting itself is prayer.
- In a group, silence is never imposed, timed competitively, or interpreted for anyone.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he is present in silence and in speech. Pray that each person will begin small, without fear of failing, and will stop and seek help if silence brings distress.

Part 3 · The Retreat

Sessions 1 to 10. Each member watches the teaching privately; the group gathers for the passage, the prayer and the silence, and does the journaling and exercise apart. Use the timetables in “Running the retreat as a group”.

Session 1: Come As You Are

Session 1 · Day 1, morning · Part 3: The Retreat · (on a member's plan view: "Your Day 1, morning")

"Do I have to arrive properly?"

Passage	Luke 15:11–24
Teaching	about 8 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Core in every plan. The one-day and three-hour plans use shorter versions (see "On a shorter plan")
Silence	10 minutes (adjustable, as Lesson 11 taught)
Exercise	Setting things down: the envelope marked "Not until Day 3", opened in Session 10
Anchor phrase	"While he was still a long way off, his father saw him." Or, shorter: "I am here."
Portrait	The father who ran (with the son and his prepared speech)

Aim

Help the group arrive as they are: the father runs before the son's speech is finished, and the welcome comes from grace, not from a well-prepared return.

Background for leaders

Luke 15 opens with Pharisees and scribes grumbling that Jesus receives sinners and eats with them (15:1–2). The parable of the father and two sons is the third of three lost-and-found stories. The session reads verses 11–24; the elder brother is left for another day.

The younger son prepares a speech: "I am no longer worthy to be called your son. Treat me as one of your hired servants." It is partly honest confession and partly a plan to earn a place. The father sees him "while he was still a long way off", feels compassion, runs, embraces and kisses him, and interrupts the speech with a robe, a ring and a feast.

Word note

splanchnizomai (Greek, "felt compassion")

Luke 15:20: to be moved with compassion. The session explains it from Luke's own stories (7:13, the widow at Nain; 10:33, the Samaritan; 15:20, the father), not from the word's parts.

Running the session in a group

Together. Passage, a brief introduction, the guided prayer and the silence (about 30 minutes in the residential weekend).

Apart. Self-assessment, journaling, and the setting-down exercise with the envelope (about 45 minutes).

Sharing. Optional sharing after lunch, not before: what someone noticed, never what is on their cards.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

On the session page: *The envelope is for ordinary demands only. A safety concern, medical need or urgent responsibility is handled now, not on Day 3.*

For couples

Done separately, at the same time, in separate spaces. The envelope is private; neither asks to see the other's cards.

For pastors and leaders

When writing the ordinary demands on the cards, include the sermon, the meeting, the pastoral situation, the building project and the person who is angry with you. All of it goes in the envelope.

Don't miss this

- The father runs before the son's speech is finished: the welcome comes from grace, not from a well-prepared return.
- The son's speech is partly honest confession and partly a plan to earn a place; the session honours the first and lets go of the second.
- "Come as you are" does not mean our condition is unimportant; change begins with being received truthfully.
- Known sin can be named now; deeper confession has its own unhurried space in Session 5.
- The envelope holds ordinary demands only, never safety or urgent matters. In a group, no one shares what is on their cards.

Close in prayer

Thank God that the Father runs to meet us while we are still a long way off. Pray that each person will arrive as they are, and set down what can wait until the end.

Session 2: Be Still and Become Present

Session 2 · Day 1, afternoon · Part 3: The Retreat · (on a member's plan view: "Your Day 1, afternoon")

"How do I become present to God when my mind is everywhere?"

Passage	Psalm 46 (with Mark 4:35–41)
Teaching	about 10 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Core in every plan. The one-day and three-hour plans use shorter versions (see "On a shorter plan")
Silence	15 minutes (or the length managed in Session 1; no need to extend it)
Exercise	A walk of noticing (20 to 30 minutes; seated version available)
Anchor phrase	"Be still, and know that I am God." Or, shorter: "God is here."
Portrait	Jesus asleep in the stern, and the disciples in the storm

Aim

Help the group practise becoming present to God in a noisy world: "be still" arrives in the middle of a psalm full of noise, and coming back is the practice.

Background for leaders

Psalm 46 is full of noise: the earth gives way, mountains shake, waters roar, nations rage and kingdoms totter. Verse 10, "Be still, and know that I am God," arrives amid that turmoil, calling for the recognition of God's sovereignty. God's people also hear it as they sing the psalm. It is not a relaxation technique.

In Mark 4:35–41 Jesus is asleep in the stern while the boat fills with water. The disciples' fear is understandable: the danger was real. The session does not shame anxiety, and professional care is not a lack of faith.

Word note

rāp̄â (Hebrew, "be still")

Psalm 46:10 (harpû, a plural command): to let go, cease, stop striving. The same verb is translated "Stop!" in 1 Samuel 15:16 and "Refrain from anger" in Psalm 37:8.

Running the session in a group

Together. Passage, prayer and silence (about 30 minutes).

Apart. Journaling and the walk of noticing, outdoors if possible and safe (about 60 minutes); a seated version is available.

Sharing. Optional sharing, 30 minutes at most, on Sessions 1 and 2. No one is asked where their attention went. Then a free evening.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

The session page has no separate safety note. The rules for sharing and "When someone is in trouble" apply as always.

For couples

Shared moment 1 follows this session: twenty minutes, each says one thing they noticed today, the other listens without responding, and each prays one sentence for the other.

For pastors and leaders

No addition in Program 7.

Don’t miss this

- “Be still” arrives in the middle of a psalm full of noise; it comes amid the turmoil of raging nations, calling for the recognition of God’s sovereignty, and God’s people hear it too as they sing the psalm.
- The stillness the psalm describes is not a calm world, but a person who knows something true in a world that is not calm.
- “Present help” does not promise a feeling; it means trouble does not place anyone beyond God’s knowledge, sovereignty or care.
- The disciples’ fear was understandable; the danger was real. Anxiety is not shamed, and professional care is not a lack of faith.
- Coming back is the practice. In a group, no one is asked where their attention went, and silence is never timed competitively.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he is a very present help in trouble, even when the world is not calm. Pray that each person will practise coming back to him gently, without shame.

Session 3: Release What You Are Carrying

Session 3 · Day 2, morning · Part 3: The Retreat

"What should I put down, and what is mine to carry?"

Passage	Matthew 11:28–30
Teaching	about 9 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Core in every plan. The one-day and three-hour plans use shorter versions (see "On a shorter plan"); the plan chooser shows only the chosen plan's steps
Silence	15 minutes, or the length you can manage
Exercise	Handing over: index cards marked A (Act), S (Share), E (Entrust) and ? (Seek counsel)
Anchor phrase	"Come to me, and I will give you rest." Or, shorter: "Gentle and lowly in heart."
Portrait	Jesus the gentle teacher, inviting the heavy laden

Aim

Help the group hear Jesus' invitation again and sort what they carry: act, share, entrust, seek counsel. His yoke is still a yoke, but its master is gentle.

Background for leaders

In Matthew 11:28–30 the yoke is an image of coming under a teacher's authority and way of life. Religious leaders had tied heavy burdens on people's shoulders without lifting a finger to move them (Matthew 23:4). Jesus offers a yoke too, but he is gentle and lowly in heart.

1 Peter 5:6–7 holds two things together: humbling ourselves under God's mighty hand, and casting all our anxieties on him, because he cares for us.

Word note

chrēstos (Greek, "easy")

Matthew 11:30: good, kind or pleasant rather than harsh. Used of God elsewhere: "kind to the ungrateful and the evil" (Luke 6:35); "the Lord is good" (1 Peter 2:3). Jesus' yoke is still a yoke; the one who calls us is gentle.

Running the session in a group

Together. Passage, prayer and silence (about 30 minutes).

Apart. Journaling and the cards: the list, marked A (Act), S (Share), E (Entrust) and ? (Seek counsel) (about 60 minutes).

Sharing. Optional sharing, 30 minutes at most. No one reads out their list or their cards. Then a long break before lunch: Session 4 must not follow directly.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

On the session page: *Release never means withdrawing a report, cancelling a boundary or relieving someone of accountability for harm.*

For couples

Done separately. Cards stay private.

For pastors and leaders

Ministers habitually mark everything Act. Pay particular attention to the Share and Seek-counsel marks: Jethro's answer to Moses was a shared load.

Don't miss this

- Rest begins in relationship with Christ, not in a technique; burdens laid on people in God's name are still burdens, and Jesus still says "Come."
- Jesus does not take the yoke away. His yoke is still a yoke; its master is gentle and lowly in heart. Rest and discipleship belong together.
- Release does not mean "drop everything": it means act, share, entrust, and seek counsel.
- Release is never silence about harm, and never cancels a report, a boundary or an offender's accountability.
- In a group, no one reads out their list or their cards. Leaders watch for distress and follow the pause rule.

Close in prayer

Thank God that Jesus says "Come" to the weary and heavy laden. Pray that each person will know what is theirs to carry, and hand over the rest.

Session 4: Lament, Grief, and Honest Prayer

Session 4 · Day 2, afternoon · Part 3: The Retreat

"Am I allowed to pray like this?"

Passage	Psalm 13
Teaching	about 9 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Three-day plan, Day 2 afternoon; may be skipped for very recent or overwhelming loss. At-home Day 4. Not in the one-day or three-hour plans: the chooser says so
Silence	10 minutes, deliberately shorter; five minutes is enough, or none
Exercise	Writing your own lament: brief, general or full; all three are complete
Anchor phrase	"How long, O LORD?" Or, if that is too raw today: "Consider and answer me."
Portrait	The psalmist who asks "How long?" four times, and still says "I have trusted"

Aim

Help the group see that lament is a God-given way to pray: honest protest is permitted, God kept the laments, and grief with no funeral can be named.

Background for leaders

Psalm 13 asks "How long?" four times in two verses, then asks God to consider and answer, and ends: "But I have trusted in your steadfast love." Laments are roughly a third of the Psalms. Their usual shape is address, complaint, petition and trust, but Psalm 88 ends in darkness, and it is also in the book.

Jesus wept at Lazarus' tomb (John 11:35) and prayed Psalm 22 on the cross (Mark 15:34). Job 42:7 and Jeremiah 20:7 (with Psalm 44:23) show that honest protest is permitted; not every conclusion drawn in grief is a full description of God.

Word note

No word is taught, as the course structure says: "How long?" needs no explanation.

Running the session in a group

Together. Passage, prayer and a short silence (about 25 minutes). The silence is deliberately shorter: five minutes is enough, or none.

Apart. Journaling and writing a lament: brief, general or full; all three are complete (about 60 minutes).

Sharing. No sharing. A long break follows. The quiet room is staffed. Session 5 is not done the same evening in a group.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

On the session page: *If your loss is very recent or overwhelming, or memory exercises trigger panic or flashbacks, you may skip this session and choose rest or supported prayer.*

For couples

Shared moment 2 follows the long break after this session: twenty minutes, each says one thing today was like. “I cannot talk tonight” is a complete answer. Do not ask about the lament.

For pastors and leaders

Ministers carry a grief that rarely gets named: the ministry that did not become what they hoped, the people who left, the vision that failed, the church that hurt them while they were serving it. Give it a card. Use the general lament if the specific one is too close.

Don’t miss this

- Laments are roughly a third of the Psalms; God kept all of them, including Psalm 88, which ends in the dark.
- Address, complaint, petition, trust: a pattern and a permission. Trust can be spoken while the situation is unresolved, and a blank fourth part is still an honest lament.
- Much grief has no funeral. Name the invisible losses gently.
- Jesus wept, and prayed Psalm 22 on the cross. Honest protest is permitted; not every conclusion drawn in grief is a full description of God.
- In a group, no one shares their lament, and leaders never interpret anyone’s grief. A quiet room is staffed; Session 5 is not done the same evening in a group.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he kept the laments, even Psalm 88. Pray for each person carrying grief, named or unnamed, that they will know they may bring it to him honestly.

Session 5: Confession and Grace

Session 5 · Day 2, evening, or Day 3, morning · Part 3: The Retreat

"How do I confess without punishing myself?"

Passage	Psalm 51:1–12
Teaching	about 10 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Three-day plan: Day 2 evening only if settled, otherwise Day 3 morning (Route B). At-home: Day 6 (only if settled). Not in the one-day or three-hour plans: the chooser says so
Silence	15 minutes, or the length you can manage
Exercise	Confession and assurance: cards, 1 John 1:9 and Psalm 103:12 read aloud, an envelope marked "Forgiven". May be skipped by anyone the scrupulosity note applies to
Anchor phrase	"According to your steadfast love." Or, shorter: "Have mercy on me."
Portrait	David confronted by Nathan, praying for mercy and for restored joy

Aim

Help members confess without punishing themselves: Psalm 51 begins with God's steadfast love, confession to God and accountability for harm belong together, and not every limitation is sin.

Background for leaders

The traditional heading links Psalm 51 to David after Nathan's confrontation over Bathsheba and Uriah (2 Samuel 11–12; "You are the man!", 12:7). "Against you, you only, have I sinned" does not erase Bathsheba and Uriah: confession to God and accountability for harm belong together.

The psalm asks for more than forgiveness: a clean heart, a right spirit, and the joy of salvation restored (51:10–12). The woman who loved much (Luke 7:36–50) and 1 John 1:9 belong in the background.

Word note

ḥesed (Hebrew, "steadfast love")

Psalm 51:1: God's loyal, merciful love, his faithfulness to his people; the ground of the whole prayer. Shown with Exodus 34:6, "abounding in steadfast love and faithfulness".

Running the session in a group

Together. The passage and the introduction only (about 15 minutes).

Apart. Prayer, journaling and the exercise in complete privacy (about 60 minutes). No personal confession is spoken to the group or the facilitator.

Sharing. No sharing. A break follows. Not done on a Sunday evening in a group; in a weekly group, take a week off between Sessions 4 and 5.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

On the session page: *If you struggle with scrupulosity or repeated confession, you may skip the written exercise. If what surfaces involves harm to another person or someone's safety, seek qualified guidance about accountability and reporting.*

For couples

Done separately. The confession is private.

For pastors and leaders

Two cautions. Beware producing a confession that would sound right from a pulpit; use Hannah's honesty. If what surfaces involves misconduct, the safeguarding guidance applies with particular force: forgiveness and fellowship are not the same as return to office. Seek qualified guidance about accountability and reporting; do not use the retreat to manage it privately.

Don't miss this

- Psalm 51 begins with God's steadfast love, not with the sin. That order is central to the theology of confession.
- "Against you, you only" does not erase Bathsheba and Uriah: confession to God and accountability for harm belong together.
- Not every limitation is sin. Silence is not an infallible detector of sin; test what surfaces.
- Scrupulosity: the written exercise may be skipped; never add a rule about how often or how perfectly to confess.
- In a group, no one is asked to confess, share, or show a card. Serious matters go to qualified people; leaders know their reporting obligations. Session 5 is not done on a Sunday evening in a group.

Close in prayer

Thank God that his steadfast love comes before our confession. Pray that each person will receive his mercy without punishing themselves, and that anyone carrying something serious will seek the right help.

Session 6: Forgiving Others and Yourself

Session 6 · Optional · Part 3: The Retreat

"What does forgiveness ask of me, and what does it not ask?"

Passage	Matthew 18:21–35
Teaching	about 12 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Not in the three-day, one-day, three-hour, couples or pastors' plans: the chooser says so and points to Lesson 16's week 4 or a supported setting. Extended at-home retreat: Day 8, after a second rest day, only if the conditions are met
Silence	10 minutes, deliberately short
Exercise	The default prayer, written or prayed without writing ("God, I place this wound in your care and ask for help with the next faithful step"); an optional card for those who are ready and safe, sealed in an envelope marked "Placed in God's care"
Anchor phrase	"Into your hands I place this wound." Or: "God sees and God cares." Or: "Show me the next faithful step."
Portrait	Joseph, who remembered every detail, tested his brothers, and refused vengeance

Aim

Help members see what forgiveness asks and does not ask: release is not reconciliation, no one is required to contact or return to someone who harmed them, and forgiveness never replaces safeguarding.

Background for leaders

In Matthew 18:21–35 Peter asks how often he must forgive, and Jesus answers with a parable: a servant forgiven ten thousand talents (an unpayable debt) refuses to forgive a fellow servant a hundred denarii. The parable carries both mercy and a warning, but the warning must never be used to coerce wounded people into declaring forgiveness on demand.

Matthew 18:15–17 sets forgiveness inside truth-telling, but those steps are not a procedure for abuse. Joseph remembered every detail and tested his brothers before restoring the relationship, and refused vengeance (Genesis 42–44; 50:15–21). Romans 12:19 leaves vengeance to God, and Romans 13:1–4 gives the authorities their proper role.

The session separates five movements that the one word "forgiveness" is often asked to carry. It has the one fair "Christians differ" slide (Romans 12:19) and a still safety card.

Word note

No word is taught, as the structure says. The book's settled vocabulary carries the session: truth, safety, justice, release, reconciliation.

Running the session in a group

Together. If used at all in a group: the passage and a brief introduction only.

Apart. Everything else, privately: the default prayer, and an optional card only for those who are ready and safe.

Sharing. No sharing. No one is asked to share or show a card. Include Session 6 only if the group is small and well established and the leader has considered its conditions carefully; take a week off between Sessions 5 and 6.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

On the session page: *You are never required to contact or return to someone who harmed you. Forgiveness never replaces safeguarding or reporting. Consider doing this session with a pastor or trauma-informed professional.*

For couples

Not part of the couples' plan. It remains available in week 4 of the 30-day plan, or in a supported setting.

For pastors and leaders

Not part of the pastors' plan. If the harm involves people the pastor serves, safeguarding and reporting come first.

Don't miss this

- Release is not reconciliation. Release does not wait for the other person; reconciliation always needs more than one.
- No one is ever asked to contact or return to someone who harmed them.
- Forgiveness never replaces safeguarding or reporting.
- The warning in the parable must never be used to coerce wounded people into declaring forgiveness on demand.
- In a group, include Session 6 only if the group is small and well established and the leader has considered its conditions carefully; take a week off between Sessions 5 and 6. No one is asked to share or show a card.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he sees every wrong and that vengeance belongs to him. Pray for anyone carrying harm done to them, that they will be safe, supported, and never pressed to forgive on demand.

Session 7: Listening for God's Direction

Session 7 · Day 3, morning · Part 3: The Retreat

"How do I listen for God without mistaking my own voice for his?"

Passage	1 Kings 19:9–18 (with 1 Samuel 3:1–10)
Teaching	about 12 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Three-day: Day 3, late morning (Route A) or midday after Session 5 and a long break (Route B). One-day: mid-afternoon, shortened (about 45 minutes, silence ten minutes), and may be dropped. At-home: Day 7 (core) or Day 9 (extended). Couples and pastors: as the three-day plan. Not in the three-hour reset
Silence	20 minutes, the longest of the retreat; ten is a complete practice, and so is five
Exercise	Listening with Scripture (twenty to thirty minutes): three slow readings, then one card, "What I sense" and "What I will test it against", kept with the Session 3 cards
Anchor phrase	"Speak, LORD, for your servant hears." Or, shorter: "Here I am."
Portrait	Elijah at Horeb, the central thread of the course from the broom tree (Lesson 1); Samuel and Eli

Aim

Help members listen for God without mistaking their own voice for his: spectacle is not direction, God answered Elijah with correction, companionship and a task, and every impression is tested against Scripture.

Background for leaders

At Horeb, the covenant mountain, God asks Elijah twice, "What are you doing here?" The LORD was not in the wind, the earthquake or the fire. Elijah's narrowed picture ("I, even I only, am left") is corrected: seven thousand remain. God gives him a task and a companion, Elisha, not a full explanation (1 Kings 19:9–18).

Samuel needed Eli to recognise the voice and to tell him what to say: "Speak, LORD, for your servant hears" (1 Samuel 3:1–10). Scripture is the church's authoritative written standard (2 Timothy 3:16–17); every impression is tested by it.

Word note

qôl dĕmāmâ daqqâ (Hebrew, 1 Kings 19:12)

ESV "the sound of a low whisper" (footnote: "Or a sound, a thin silence"); KJV "a still small voice"; NRSV "a sound of sheer silence". The session never says simply that God spoke in a whisper: the point is that the LORD was not in the wind, the earthquake or the fire. dĕmāmâ belongs to the same family as the stillness words of Lessons 8 and 11.

Running the session in a group

Together. Passage, prayer and silence (about 35 minutes). This is the longest silence of the retreat: twenty minutes, but ten is a complete practice, and so is five.

Apart. Journaling and listening with Scripture: three slow readings, then one card, "What I sense" and "What I will test it against" (about 60 minutes).

Sharing. Optional sharing, 30 minutes at most, after lunch: only what someone noticed. No one is asked to report what God "said" to them.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

On the session page: *Unless immediate safety requires it, make no major or irreversible decision on retreat. A voice that commands harm is not God: seek urgent help.*

For couples

Done separately. The “What I sense” card is private.

For pastors and leaders

Ministers are practised at hearing God for other people. Bring your own question, not the church’s. Some ministry roles need to change or end for reasons of health, truth or safety. A personal impression does not bypass elders, boards, denominational oversight or the church’s ordinary processes.

Don’t miss this

- The passage does not teach that God always whispers; it teaches not to equate spectacle with divine direction.
- God answered Elijah with correction, companionship and a task, not a full explanation.
- Scripture first: only Scripture is the church’s authoritative written standard; every impression is tested.
- No major or irreversible decision on retreat. A voice that commands harm is not God: seek urgent help.
- In a group, sharing is optional and limited to what someone noticed; no one is asked to report what God “said” to them.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he speaks through his word and is not found in spectacle. Pray that each person will listen humbly, test what they sense, and make no hasty decisions.

Session 8: Rediscovering Your Identity

Session 8 · Flex session · Part 3: The Retreat

"Who am I when my roles are set aside?"

Passage	Matthew 3:13–17, followed by Matthew 4:1–11; then Matthew 3:17 again on its own
Teaching	about 10 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Three-day: Day 3 mid-afternoon on Route A only, and only if genuinely rested (one of Sessions 8 and 9); otherwise the 30-day plan (week 2). Extended at-home: Day 10. Not in the one-day, three-hour or core at-home plans (the 30-day plan instead). Pastors: Program 7 recommends Session 9 as the flex session
Silence	15 minutes, or the length you can manage; sitting, standing, slow walking or gentle movement are all permitted
Exercise	What I do, what matters, what remains: three columns, then an index card with three or four lines from the third column, kept somewhere private and useful
Anchor phrase	"See what love the Father has given us." Or: "Abba, Father." If parental language is difficult: "Nothing can separate me from the love of God in Christ."
Portrait	Jesus at the Jordan and in the wilderness

Aim

Help members find what remains true when roles are set aside: the Father called Jesus beloved before any public ministry, and those who belong to Christ are children, not slaves.

Background for leaders

At the Jordan the Father says, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased" (Matthew 3:17) before Jesus' public work begins (Luke 2 hints at faithful, hidden years before it). In the wilderness the tempter begins, "If you are the Son of God…" (Matthew 4:3, 6).

Believers are adopted children through Christ (Galatians 4:6–7; 1 John 3:1). The Son's sonship is unique: the session does not make the two identical. Roles matter and a lost role is a real loss, but worth is received, not earned.

Word note

agāpētos (Greek, "beloved")

Matthew 3:17: loved, dearly loved; from agapaō, "to love". Spoken of the Son before any public ministry. ESV footnote: "Or my Son, my (or the) Beloved".

Running the session in a group

Together. Passage, prayer and silence, as in other sessions (a flex session; not in the residential weekend timetable).

Apart. Journaling and the three columns: what I do, what matters, what remains; then an index card from the third column.

Sharing. No one is asked to share their columns. In a weekly group, open the next meeting with brief optional sharing of what someone noticed.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

On the session page: *If a sense of worthlessness is persistent or comes with hopelessness or thoughts of death, please seek professional care.*

For couples

Not part of the couples' plan; it may be taken in the 30-day plan (week 2).

For pastors and leaders

Program 7 recommends Session 9, not Session 8, as the one flex session for pastors.

Don't miss this

- The Father's declaration comes before the public work: identity is received, not earned.
- The Son's sonship is unique; believers are adopted children through him. Do not make the two identical.
- Roles matter. This session honours callings; it does not ask anyone to erase them, and a lost role is a real loss.
- This is not positive thinking. Persistent worthlessness, especially with hopelessness or thoughts of death, needs professional care.
- Where parental language is painful, offer Romans 8:39 instead of "Abba, Father". In a group, no one is asked to share their columns.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he calls his children beloved before they do anything. Pray for anyone whose worth has become attached to usefulness, and for anyone for whom parental language is painful.

Session 9: Renewing Your Purpose

Session 9 · Flex session · Part 3: The Retreat

"Where does purpose come from when love has gone quiet?"

Passage	John 21:15–19
Teaching	about 10 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Three-day: Day 3 mid-afternoon on Route A only (one of Sessions 8 and 9); otherwise week 3 of the 30-day plan. Extended at-home: Day 11. Pastors: Program 7 recommends it as the one flex session. Not in the one-day, three-hour or core at-home plans
Silence	15 minutes, or the length you can manage
Exercise	A purpose for this season: four questions, one sentence, and "One faithful thing", on an index card; anything larger on a card marked "To test"
Anchor phrase	"Lord, you know everything." Or, if it is honest today: "Lord, you know that I love you."
Portrait	Peter on the shore, restored after failure

Aim

Help members see that purpose is given in relationship with Christ, even after failure, and write one sentence for this season and one faithful thing.

Background for leaders

On the shore, Jesus asks Peter three times, "Do you love me?" The three questions recall the three denials, and each answer is met with work: "Feed my lambs… Tend my sheep… Feed my sheep" (John 21:15–19). Purpose was given to someone who had just failed.

Restoration is not automatic return to office: serious misconduct may permanently disqualify someone from certain roles, even where repentance is genuine. "Feed my sheep" was Peter's commission; most people should not call others "my sheep". Matthew 22:37–39, Micah 6:8 and Ephesians 2:10 frame purpose for every believer.

Word note

No word is taught. The course deliberately does not teach the two Greek words for love in this passage: the difference is widely debated and would carry more than it can bear.

Running the session in a group

Together. Passage, prayer and silence (a flex session).

Apart. Journaling and the purpose exercise: four questions, one sentence, and "One faithful thing" on a card. Anything larger goes on a card marked "To test".

Sharing. No one is asked to say whether they love Jesus, or to share their sentence.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

The session page has no separate safety note. The rules for sharing and "When someone is in trouble" apply as always.

For couples

Not part of the couples' plan; it may be taken in the 30-day plan (week 3).

For pastors and leaders

Do it. "Do you love me?" asked of someone who has fed sheep professionally for years is the retreat's most important question for ministers. Answer it without the pulpit voice. Program 7 recommends it as the one flex session.

Don't miss this

- Purpose is given in relationship with Christ, and was given to someone who had just failed: it is not a reward for success.
- Restoration is not automatic return to office. Serious misconduct may permanently disqualify someone from certain roles, even where repentance is genuine.
- "Feed my sheep" was Peter's commission. Most people should not call others "my sheep".
- This is not a career-change session: anything larger goes on a "To test" card.
- The course does not teach the two Greek words for love in John 21. In a group, no one is asked to say whether they love Jesus.

Close in prayer

Thank God that Jesus restored Peter and gave him work again. Pray that each person will receive their purpose from Christ, not earn it, and take one faithful step.

Session 10: Returning With a New Rhythm

Session 10 · Day 3, late afternoon · Part 3: The Retreat

"How do I go home without losing what happened here?"

Passage	1 Kings 19:19–21, followed by Luke 10:17–20 (with Mark 6:31 and Numbers 6:24–26)
Teaching	about 9 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
In the plans	Core in every plan. Three-day: Day 3, late afternoon or early evening. One-day: 16:05, shortened. Three-hour: the last twenty-five minutes. At-home: Day 8 (core) or Day 12 (extended). Couples: followed by the third shared moment. Pastors: Program 7's notes on rhythm, support and re-entry
Silence	10 minutes, the last silence of the retreat
Exercise	Open the envelope and sort the cards (A, S, E, ?); four things to take home (one to entrust, one action, one person, one rhythm); sort all cards into action cards and private cards; the blessing (Numbers 6:24–26)
Anchor phrase	"Go, return on your way." Or: "I am not alone."
Portrait	Elijah and Elisha, the end of the Elijah thread that began under the broom tree (Lesson 1)

Aim

Help members go home without losing what happened: a retreat intends to return, take home rhythm not resolutions, expect a dip, and rejoice in belonging rather than in the quality of the retreat.

Background for leaders

Elijah, sent back the way he came ("Go, return on your way", 1 Kings 19:15), throws his cloak over Elisha, who leaves his oxen and goes after Elijah and assists him (19:19–21). Isolation gives way to shared work.

The seventy-two return rejoicing that even the demons are subject to them; Jesus redirects their joy: "rejoice that your names are written in heaven" (Luke 10:17–20). Mark 6:31 shows withdrawal and return as a pattern of life. The session ends with the blessing of Numbers 6:24–26.

Word note

šûḇ (Hebrew, "return")

1 Kings 19:15, "Go, return on your way": to turn back, return; here, to go back the way he came. In this verse it does not carry the full meaning of repentance it has elsewhere. It is the session's anchor phrase.

Running the session in a group

Together. Passage and prayer first (about 20 minutes), then the closing: each may share one card, optionally, and the leader reads the blessing over the group.

Apart. Journaling, opening the envelope from Session 1, sorting the cards, and the four things to take home: one to entrust, one action, one person, one rhythm (about 60 minutes).

Sharing. At the closing, each may share one card, optionally. Confession and release envelopes are never reopened or shared. Then departure, with the travel cautions from the session.

Repeat the rules for sharing before any sharing time. Anyone may leave the silence or the session without explanation.

Safety and care

On the session page: *If a card concerns immediate safety, medical care or abuse, do not place it in the 30-day plan; seek help now.*

For couples

Shared moment 3 follows: up to an hour, each shares the rhythm they hope to establish and any practical action that affects the marriage; other cards are optional. They agree how to protect each other's rhythm, and read the blessing together.

For pastors and leaders

Consider a weekly protected period of ceasing that the congregation knows about and a leadership team protects. For the one person, consider a supervisor or peer group outside the church. Do not preach or publicly announce what you believe you heard for at least a month.

Don't miss this

- A retreat intends to return: the returning matters as much as the leaving.
- Take home rhythm, not resolutions: one small, repeatable pattern.
- Some people notice a dip in the first days home; it does not necessarily mean the retreat was unhelpful. Severe distress needs help.
- Rejoice in belonging, not in the quality of the retreat: if the days were dry, belonging is not diminished.
- In a group, each may share one card, optionally; the leader reads the blessing over the group. Confession and release envelopes are never reopened or shared.

Close in prayer

Read Numbers 6:24–26 over the group as the blessing. Then pray that each person will return home with one small rhythm, one person, and the knowledge that they belong.

Part 4 · Come Home Well

Lessons 12 to 16, across the first 30 days home. Lesson 12 is watched privately on the first morning; Lesson 15 is for whenever it applies.

Lesson 12: Testing What You Believe You Heard

Lesson 12 · Book chapter 13 · Part 4: Come Home Well · For the first morning home

"How do I know whether it was God?"

Passage	1 Thessalonians 5:19–22 · Acts 17:11
Teaching	about 20 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	The Bereans; Gideon's fleece
Christians differ	On how God guides today and what kinds of prophecy continue; the lesson does not settle it, and says every tradition agrees on testing (Slide 6)
Builds on	Session 7 (the "What I sense" card, the nine tests and Eli), as the design says; also Session 9 ("To test" cards), Session 10 (expect a dip), Lesson 5 (safety; the tests introduced) and Lesson 11 (sensing nothing is a complete outcome)

Aim for the meeting

Help the group see testing as an act of faith, not doubt: sort what was brought home, apply the safety exception first, and ask an Eli to help test, not to confirm.

Background for leaders

Paul tells a young church, "Do not quench the Spirit. Do not despise prophecies, but test everything; hold fast what is good. Abstain from every form of evil" (1 Thessalonians 5:19–22). Both commands belong together: openness and examination.

The Bereans received the word with all eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so (Acts 17:11). Gideon's fleece is recorded, not commended (Judges 6:36–40): it is not a method the lesson recommends.

Christians differ on how God guides today and what kinds of prophecy continue. The lesson does not settle it, and says every tradition agrees on testing (Slide 6).

Word note

dokimazō (Greek, "test")

1 Thessalonians 5:21: to examine and prove genuine; used of testing metals (gold "tested by fire", 1 Peter 1:7). In 5:21 it is a present imperative, second person plural (dokimazete): a command to the whole church.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. This is the first meeting after the retreat. Welcome everyone back. Ask, in general terms only, how the return has been; expect some to describe a dip (Session 10 warned of it). No one is asked what they sensed on retreat.

Discuss the passage. Read 1 Thessalonians 5:19–22 · Acts 17:11 aloud, then ask:

1. What two things does Paul tell the Thessalonians about prophecies?

Leader's note: *Do not despise them, but test everything; hold fast what is good and abstain from every form of evil (1 Thessalonians 5:20–22).*

2. What made the Bereans "more noble"?

Leader's note: *They received the word with all eagerness and examined the Scriptures daily to see if these things were so (Acts 17:11): eagerness and care together.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Why do you think Paul told the same church both "do not despise prophecies" and "test everything"?

Leader's note: *God speaks, and we are fallible receivers. Openness without testing, or testing without openness, both go wrong.*

2. What made the Bereans "more noble", and what might eagerness and care look like together today?

Leader's note: *Eagerness and care can sit together. Keep it general.*

3. What makes someone a good "Eli" for another person? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *A good Eli helps you test, does not simply agree, and listens without defending. No one is asked who their Eli is.*

In a group, no one is asked to share their card or what they sensed.

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Sort the "What I sense" and "To test" cards into the three categories, take no major action today, fill in the testing worksheet with a start and review date, and schedule the Eli conversation.

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *Waiting and testing do not apply to immediate danger, abuse, urgent medical care or legal reporting duties: act on those now, with help.*

The safety exception comes first: waiting and testing never apply to immediate danger, abuse, urgent medical care or legal reporting duties. Those are acted on now, with help.

Questions people may ask

What if I am sure God told me to make a big change now?
Passing the tests gives a proportionate next step, not infallible certainty. Major directions are tested over weeks, with other people. When the evidence is incomplete, the answer is "not yet".

Does God still speak through prophecy today?
Christians differ. The lesson does not settle it; every tradition agrees on testing.

Extra Bible references

- **1 Thessalonians 5:19–22**: test everything; hold fast what is good
- **1 John 4:1**: test the spirits
- **Galatians 5:22–23**: the fruit of the Spirit (test two)
- **1 Samuel 3:9**: Eli helps Samuel recognise the voice

Don't miss this

- Testing is faith, not doubt: Scripture commands examination because God speaks and we are fallible receivers.
- The safety exception comes first: waiting and testing never apply to immediate danger, abuse, urgent medical care or legal reporting duties.
- Most cards are "nothing significant" or "low-risk and reversible". Only the third category gets the full testing, over weeks, with other people.
- When the evidence is incomplete, the answer is "not yet", not "no"; but a direction that clearly contradicts Scripture or requires wrongdoing is let go. Passing the tests gives a proportionate next step, not infallible certainty.
- Ask your Eli to help you test, not to confirm. Listen without defending.
- The first morning is manageable: sort, date, schedule. The nine tests come over the following days and weeks.
- In a group, never ask anyone to disclose what they sensed, and never interpret it for them.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he speaks and that he gives us his word and one another to test what we hear. Pray that each person will hold what they sensed humbly, and act on any safety matter now, with help.

Lesson 13: Turning Insight Into Action

Lesson 13 · Book chapter 14 · Part 4: Come Home Well · For the first week home

"How do I make the retreat real in ordinary life?"

Passage	James 1:22–25 · Nehemiah 1:4; 2:4–5, 17–18 (the design gives 2:11–18; verses 11–16 are described, 17–18 read)
Teaching	about 19 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Nehemiah
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Session 3 (the Act, Share, Entrust and Seek-counsel cards) and Lesson 4 (Jethro), as the design says; also Lesson 12 (anything consequential goes back to testing), Session 5 (repairs), Session 8, Session 9 (one faithful thing), Session 10 (the action, the person, and "When I miss it")

Aim for the meeting

Help the group turn insight into ordinary action, one card at a time, as Nehemiah turned a burden into a plan; and ask the Jethro questions about structures that rest cannot fix.

Background for leaders

James compares a hearer who does not act to someone who looks in a mirror and goes away and forgets what he was like (James 1:22–25). Jesus' two houses make the same point: the same words were heard; one builder did them (Luke 6:46–49).

Nehemiah wept, fasted and prayed when he heard about Jerusalem (Nehemiah 1:4). Months later, when the king asked what he wanted, he prayed and then asked specifically: leave, letters, timber (2:4–8). He inspected the walls at night before speaking (2:11–16), then invited the people to build, and divided the work into sections families could do (2:17–18; chapter 3).

Word note

No word is taught, as the course design says. James 1:25's "perseveres" is noted in English only.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Look back to Lesson 12. Ask, in general terms, whether the first-morning sorting was manageable. No one shares their cards.

Discuss the passage. Read James 1:22–25 · Nehemiah 1:4; 2:4–5, 17–18 (the design gives 2:11–18; verses 11–16 are described, 17–18 read) aloud, then ask:

1. What is the person who hears but does not do like, according to James?

Leader's note: *Like someone who looks at his face in a mirror, goes away, and at once forgets what he was like (James 1:23–24).*

2. What did Nehemiah do between hearing the news and starting the work?

Leader's note: *He wept, fasted and prayed; months later he asked the king for specific things; he inspected the walls at night; then he invited the people and divided the work (Nehemiah 1–2).*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. What is the difference between hearing a sermon and doing something with it? What helps you to do?

Leader's note: *Doing is usually small and specific: one step, a date, a person.*

2. What stands out to you in the way Nehemiah moved from prayer to a plan?

Leader's note: *Insight, then time, a plan with specifics, a quiet look at the facts, work in pieces people can do.*

3. Which Jethro question is hardest to answer honestly? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Keep this general; no one names their workplace or family situation.*

In a group, no one is asked to share their cards or the details of a repair.

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). The book's minimum two-week plan: one Act step, one Share conversation, one Seek-counsel appointment or access step, and the five Jethro questions; more only if capacity allows.

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *Do not contact someone to apologise if contact would be unsafe, unwanted or legally restricted; seek guidance first.*

Questions people may ask

Should I apologise to someone I hurt?
Apologies centre the other person, never oblige them, and are not made where contact would be unsafe, unwanted or legally restricted. Seek guidance first in those cases.

What if my counselling appointment is weeks away?
A Seek-counsel card's first step is complete when the appointment is booked. Do not let an unavailable appointment become no action: keep the card until the guidance has been received.

Extra Bible references

- **Luke 6:46–49**: the two houses
- **Exodus 18:17–23**: Jethro's counsel (Lesson 4)
- **Nehemiah 4:6**: the people had a mind to work
- **Philippians 2:12–13**: work out your salvation; God works in you

Don't miss this

- On retreat we listened and began to respond; now that obedience continues in ordinary life. Not dramatic; actual.
- Nehemiah's shape: insight, then time, a plan with specifics, a quiet look at the facts, work in pieces people can do.
- One card at a time: one Act step this week; Share cards need three sentences; Seek-counsel cards: the first step is complete when the appointment is booked; keep the card until the needed guidance has been received and the next step considered; Entrust cards have no action.
- Apologies centre the other person, never oblige them, and are not made where contact would be unsafe, unwanted or restricted.
- Rest does not fix a structure: ask the five Jethro questions and, where change is possible, request one structural change.
- In a group, no one is asked to disclose their cards.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he gives us work we can do, piece by piece. Pray that each person will take one step this week, share one burden, and ask for one change where it is possible.

Lesson 14: Building a Sustainable Rule of Life

Lesson 14 · Book chapter 15 · Part 4: Come Home Well · For the second and third weeks home

"What small pattern will carry me?"

Passage	Mark 2:23–28 (vv. 27–28 read) with Deuteronomy 5:12–15 (v. 15 read) · Acts 2:42 (with Daniel 6:10)
Teaching	about 18 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Daniel at his window
Christians differ	One fair slide (Slide 12): the seventh day; Sunday, the Lord's Day, with differing views on a Christian Sabbath; the Sabbath fulfilled in Christ (Colossians 2:16–17; Romans 14:5–6; Hebrews 4:9–11)
Builds on	Lesson 2 (šāḇaṯ; rest declares that God holds the world) and Session 10 (one rhythm), as the design says; also Lesson 8 (the daily psalm and silence), Lesson 9 (screens), Lesson 10 (sleep and body), Lesson 13 (the Jethro conversation), and the couples and pastors plans

Aim for the meeting

Help the group shape a small rule of life: a trellis, not a cage, with Sabbath at the centre, three core commitments, and resuming without guilt.

Background for leaders

By Jesus' time the Sabbath had gathered burdensome rules; he healed on the Sabbath and asked, "Is it lawful on the Sabbath to do good or to do harm?" (Mark 3:4). "The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath" (Mark 2:27). Exodus grounds it in creation; Deuteronomy 5:15 in liberation.

Daniel prayed three times a day at his window "as he had done previously" (Daniel 6:10): the pattern was there before the pressure came. Acts 2:42 is a rule of life in one sentence. Benedict's sixth-century Rule intended nothing harsh or burdensome.

Christians differ: some keep the seventh day; many worship on Sunday, the Lord's Day, with differing views on a Christian Sabbath; others understand the command as fulfilled in Christ (Colossians 2:16–17; Romans 14:5–6; Hebrews 4:9–11). The lesson has one fair slide and requires no position.

Word note

šāḇaṯ (recalled) (Hebrew, "to cease")

No new word. Slide 5 recalls šāḇaṯ from Lesson 2 (Genesis 2:2), in Lesson 2's wording. The Sabbath is first of all a stopping.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. Look back to Lessons 2 and 13. Ask, in general terms, whether the one Act step from Lesson 13 happened. No one is asked for details.

Discuss the passage. Read Mark 2:23–28 (vv. 27–28 read) with Deuteronomy 5:12–15 (v. 15 read) · Acts 2:42 (with Daniel 6:10) aloud, then ask:

1. What does Jesus say the Sabbath was made for?

Leader's note: *"The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath. So the Son of Man is lord even of the Sabbath" (Mark 2:27–28).*

2. What four things did the first believers devote themselves to?

Leader's note: *The apostles' teaching and the fellowship, the breaking of bread and the prayers (Acts 2:42).*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. What is the difference between a trellis and a cage in your own experience of spiritual disciplines?

Leader's note: *A trellis supports growth; a cage confines. Let people name the difference without confessing failures.*

2. Why do you think Daniel's ordinary pattern mattered so much when the pressure came?

Leader's note: *His pattern was there before the crisis; faithfulness others could set a clock by.*

3. What would Sabbath look like in your week, honestly? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Christians who keep different days, or none, are treated with the same respect (Romans 14:5–6). No one is asked to share their rule.*

In a group, Christians who keep different days or none are treated with the same respect (Romans 14:5–6). No one is asked to share their rule.

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Write your one-page rule of life (three core lines, at most two optional), with the resume line, a two-week check and three-month review date, and the person you will share it with.

Safety and care

This lesson page has no separate safety note. The rules for sharing and "When someone is in trouble" apply as always.

Questions people may ask

Which day is the Christian Sabbath?

Christians differ. The course requires no position: follow Scripture conscientiously, consider your church's teaching, and respect believers who differ. Whatever the conviction: worship, rest, mercy and a sustainable rhythm.

What if I am a carer and cannot take a full day?

Safe respite is not selfish. If none is available, Sabbath fragments count: a protected hour, help with one task, prayer while someone else sits with them. A half-day kept for a year beats a full day never taken.

Extra Bible references

- **Galatians 5:1**: for freedom Christ has set us free
- **Exodus 16:22–30**: the manna and the seventh day
- **Hebrews 4:9–11**: a Sabbath rest remains
- **Daniel 6:10**: as he had done previously

Don't miss this

- A rule of life is a trellis, not a cage: a small chosen pattern, never a way to earn approval (Galatians 5:1).
- Sabbath at the centre: creation and liberation; "made for man"; not neglect of mercy or necessary care.
- Christians differ: the seventh day, Sunday as the Lord's Day (with or without a Christian Sabbath), or the Sabbath fulfilled in Christ. Respect each other's convictions (Romans 14:5–6).
- Three core commitments, one page, small enough for a difficult ordinary week; at most two optional lines.
- Resume without punishment, compensation, or guilt; check at two weeks, review at three months.
- In a group, no one is asked to share their rule.

Close in prayer

Thank God that the Sabbath was made for us. Pray that each person will write a small rule they can keep in a difficult ordinary week, and resume without guilt when they miss.

Lesson 15: When You Need a Pastor, Counsellor, or Mental-Health Professional

Lesson 15 · Book chapter 16 · Part 4: Come Home Well · For any week, whenever it applies

"When is it more than tiredness, and who can help?"

Passage	Proverbs 15:22 · Galatians 6:2
Teaching	about 15 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Luke, the beloved physician
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Lesson 5 (a retreat cannot replace care; the objections; the safety sections), as the design says; also Lesson 4 (where pastoral description stops), Session 4 (grief), Session 10 (the dip), Lesson 13 (do not let an unavailable appointment become no action), Lesson 14 (the rule of life) and the pastors' plan

Aim for the meeting

Help the group know when it is more than tiredness and who can help, without anyone being asked about their own health. In a group, keep every question general.

Background for leaders

"Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed" (Proverbs 15:22). Proverbs teaches the wisdom of counsel in making decisions; it is not a map of modern health services, but its principle holds. "Bear one another's burdens" (Galatians 6:2) was met in Lesson 5.

Paul calls Luke "the beloved physician" (Colossians 4:14); he travelled with Paul and is traditionally understood to have written a Gospel and Acts. Paul gave Timothy practical advice about his health (1 Timothy 5:23). Early Christians did not set faith against ordinary means of care.

Word note

No word is taught, as the course design says.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. This lesson is for whenever it applies; members watch it privately. If you meet about it, say at the start that no one will be asked about their own mental health, diagnosis or treatment, and that you will not give medical advice. Point everyone to the safety card at the top of the lesson page.

Discuss the passage. Read Proverbs 15:22, Galatians 6:2 and Colossians 4:14 (shown on screen in the lesson) aloud, then ask:

1. What does Proverbs 15:22 say about plans and advisers?

Leader's note: *Without counsel plans fail, but with many advisers they succeed.*

2. Who was Luke, and what does that suggest?

Leader's note: *"The beloved physician", Paul's companion. Early Christians did not set faith against ordinary means of care.*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Why do you think Christians often go only to a pastor first?

Leader's note: *A pastor is the person people know, but not the right first call for everything. Most serious difficulties need more than one kind of help.*

2. What helps a church be a place where people can say they are not well?

Leader's note: *Keep this about the church, not about anyone in the room.*

3. What would you want from a friend who told you they were unsure what they believe? Share your own experience only if you wish.

Leader's note: *A crisis of faith is not a mental-health condition. Do not panic; listen. No one is asked whether they are in doubt.*

In a group, no one is asked about their own mental health, diagnosis, or treatment, and the leader does not give medical advice.

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). If any sign applies: name the kind of help that is the right first call, answer any objection, and take one step this week. If none applies: note who you would call.

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *If you may act on thoughts of suicide or are in immediate danger, contact emergency services or go to the nearest emergency department now.*

Know the safety card at the top of the page: if someone may act on thoughts of suicide, has a plan or the means, cannot keep themselves safe, or is in immediate danger from another person, they contact emergency services or go to the nearest emergency department now. Suicidal thoughts without a plan or intention still need prompt professional help, the same day. If anything like this arises in a meeting, follow "When someone is in trouble".

Questions people may ask

Is taking medication a sign of weak faith?
Medication is a medical treatment, not a verdict on faith. Decisions are made with a qualified prescriber. A leader never advises anyone to start, stop or change medication.

Should I just tell my pastor?
Pastors are essential, but not trained to treat everything. The lesson's table shows who does what; the urgent and specialised needs come first.

Extra Bible references

- **Galatians 6:1–5**: bearing burdens, and carrying your own load
- **Psalm 88**: a lament that ends in darkness
- **Mark 9:24**: I believe; help my unbelief
- **Colossians 4:12–14**: Luke among Paul's companions

Don't miss this

- Safety first: anyone in immediate danger acts now; suicidal thoughts without a plan still need prompt professional help; the lesson can wait.
- Faithfulness without improvement, over weeks, is a reason to seek help, not to try harder.
- The right first call, and usually more than one kind of help; a pastor is one part, not the whole.
- Faith and help together: prayer leads towards truthful help. Do not start, stop or change medication because of a retreat experience.
- Leaders find help outside their own church. A crisis of faith is not a mental-health condition; talk to someone who will not panic.
- In a group, never ask about anyone's mental health or treatment, and do not give medical advice.

Close in prayer

Thank God that he cares for us through many people. Pray, without naming anyone, for any who need help to have the courage to ask, and for anyone in danger to be safe today.

Lesson 16: Your 30-Day Spiritual Renewal Plan

Lesson 16 · Book chapter 17 · Part 4: Come Home Well · For Day 30

"What does the first month home look like?"

Passage	Philippians 1:6 · 1 Kings 19:15, 21 (recalled from Session 10)
Teaching	about 14 minutes, watched privately before the meeting
Portrait	Elijah sent on with a companion (the book's closing word)
Christians differ	None in this lesson
Builds on	Sessions 7 and 10 and the whole course, as the design says: Lesson 1 (the three answers), Lesson 7 (the intention), Lesson 8 (the psalms), Lessons 12 to 15 (testing, action, rhythm, help), Sessions 6, 8 and 9 (optional this month)

For leaders: This meeting reviews the first month home. It does not introduce a new 30-day plan: the plan has been on Your First 30 Days Home since the first morning back, and the lesson's title is the book's chapter title.

Aim for the meeting

Help the group look back over the month with grace: Day 30 is a review, not a deadline; the month was for imperfect repetition; and the next pause is booked.

Background for leaders

Paul wrote Philippians while imprisoned, to a church he loved and thanked God for (Philippians 1:3–7). "He who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ" (1:6). God began the work and God will complete it; the day of completion is Christ's return, not Day 30.

The course ends where it began, with Elijah: God fed him before he sent him, let him sleep, asked him what he was doing there and listened twice, redirected him, gave him work that was his and a companion and successor. He did not tell him to try harder (1 Kings 19; recalled from Session 10).

Word note

No word is taught, as the course design says.

Leading the meeting

Welcome and look back. This is the Day 30 meeting, the last of the course. Welcome everyone. Say clearly that no one will be asked to share their review, their cards or what they are still testing, and that missing most of the plan is not failing.

Discuss the passage. Read Philippians 1:3–11 (verse 6 is the focus), with 1 Kings 19:15 and 21 recalled from Session 10 aloud, then ask:

1. In Philippians 1:3–11, what is Paul sure of (verse 6), and who began the work, and who will complete it, and when?

Leader's note: *God began it and will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ.*

2. What did God give Elijah when he sent him on?

Leader's note: *Work that was his to do, and a companion and successor, Elisha (1 Kings 19:15–21).*

The three discussion questions (on the lesson page). Use the notes to guide; do not read them out as answers.

1. Where did you notice grace this month that you did not produce by effort? Share only if you wish.

Leader's note: *Begin with grace, before anything is evaluated. Sharing is optional.*

2. Why do you think a month is a review rather than a deadline?

Leader's note: *Nothing becomes overdue; testing may continue beyond Day 30.*

3. What would help you keep your next pause when the time comes?

Leader's note: *A pause in the calendar, a person who knows, a small first step. Keep it practical.*

In a group, no one is asked to share their review, their cards, or what they are testing.

This week's step (done privately; no one shares it). Book the next pause (a three-hour reset next month, a day in three months, a retreat within the year), then complete My Day 30 Review, on Day 30 or whenever you are ready.

Safety and care

On the lesson page: *If any warning sign applies, act on Lesson 15 today, whatever week of the plan you are in.*

Questions people may ask

I missed most of the plan. Have I failed?
The plan does not expire and does not need restarting. Find the next unfinished step that still matters, and begin there. The part you did may be the important part. Resume.

Do I have to do My Day 30 Review?
No. It is optional, private, not scored, and never overdue. All eight questions are on the printable worksheet.

Extra Bible references

- **Philippians 1:3–11**: partnership, and the work God completes
- **Lamentations 3:22–24**: his mercies are new every morning
- **Psalm 131**: the psalm for the fourth week
- **Numbers 6:22–27**: the blessing

Don't miss this

- Safety first: any warning sign means acting on Lesson 15 today, whatever week it is.
- The month is for imperfect repetition, not for becoming a different person in thirty days.
- Day 30 is a review, not a decision deadline. Testing may continue beyond it.
- Session 6 only if its conditions are met; leaving it for later is a legitimate decision.
- In a group, never ask anyone to share their review, cards or testing.

Close in prayer

Thank God for the grace each person received this month that they did not produce by effort. Pray that each will keep a small rhythm and their next pause. Then read the blessing over the group: "The LORD bless you and keep you; the LORD make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the LORD lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace" (Numbers 6:24–26).

The Day 30 meeting

Lesson 16 is the Day 30 meeting. If your group meets on Day 30 or soon after, use the plan for Lesson 16 above. A simple shape:

1. **Welcome** (5 minutes). Repeat the rules for sharing. No one shares their review.
2. **Grace received** (10 minutes). Five minutes of silence to recall, privately, where they noticed help, kindness, provision, truth, rest or God's presence. Optional sharing of one thing noticed.
3. **The passage** (10 minutes). Read Philippians 1:3–11 aloud; verse 6 is the focus. 1 Kings 19:15 and 21 may be read as well, recalled from Session 10.
4. **The three discussion questions** (25 minutes).
5. **The next pause** (10 minutes). Each person chooses one realistic pause and puts it in their calendar now.
6. **The blessing** (5 minutes). The leader reads Numbers 6:24–26 over the group.

Notes for leaders

- My Day 30 Review is private and optional. A leader never asks anyone whether they did it or what they wrote.
- The course page records the date a member completed their retreat plan. It records participation only, not how well the retreat went. There is no certificate and no score, and members are never compared.
- Anyone for whom a warning sign applies is pointed to Lesson 15 today, whatever week it is.

Original words in the course

Unit	Word	Meaning	Where
Lesson 1	erēmos (Greek)	desolate, a solitary place	Mark 6:31; 1:35 (recalled in Lessons 3 and 6)
Lesson 2	šāḇaṯ (Hebrew)	to cease, stop	Genesis 2:2 (recalled in Lesson 14)
Lesson 8	dāmam (Hebrew)	to be still, quieted	Psalm 131:2
Lesson 9	perispaō (Greek)	to be drawn away, distracted	Luke 10:40
Lesson 11	dûmiyyâ (Hebrew)	silence, quiet waiting	Psalm 62:1 (dōmmî, 62:5)
Session 1	splanchnizomai (Greek)	to be moved with compassion	Luke 15:20; 7:13; 10:33
Session 2	rāp̄â (Hebrew)	let go, cease, be still	Psalm 46:10
Session 3	chrēstos (Greek)	easy: good, kind	Matthew 11:30; Luke 6:35; 1 Peter 2:3
Session 5	ḥeseḏ (Hebrew)	steadfast love	Psalm 51:1; Exodus 34:6
Session 7	qôl dĕmāmâ daqqâ (Hebrew)	the sound of a low whisper, or a thin silence	1 Kings 19:12
Session 8	agāpētos (Greek)	beloved	Matthew 3:17
Session 10	šûḇ (Hebrew)	to return	1 Kings 19:15
Lesson 12	dokimazō (Greek)	to test, examine and prove genuine	1 Thessalonians 5:21; 1 Peter 1:7

No word is taught in Lessons 3 (erēmos recalled), 4, 5, 6, 7, 10, 13, 14 (šāḇaṯ recalled), 15 and 16, or in Sessions 4, 6 and 9 (the two Greek words for love in John 21 are deliberately not taught).

Finding help

Every lesson page links to the site's page Finding Help Where You Live. Emergency numbers vary by country: verify the number where your group meets before the first meeting, and keep it with the safeguarding lead's and the arranged professional contact's details. If someone is in immediate danger, may act on thoughts of suicide, cannot keep themselves safe, or has a medical emergency, call the local emergency number or go to the nearest emergency department. Do not delay urgent help while searching for the perfect service.